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Construction of Mega Infrastructure Projects like Atal Setu, Sudarshan Setu, Chenab Rail Bridge and Bogibeel Bridge



CBC-37101/13/0002/2627

DEAL REACHED: US, IRAN SET TO SIGN PACT ENDING 107-DAY WAR

The peace pen awaits Friday

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA / ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON/ ISLAM-ABAD: President Donald Trump has announced that the US and Iran have finalised a deal to end their 107-day war, which triggered a global energy crisis. The peace agreement is scheduled to be signed on June 19 in Switzerland, according to Pakistan Prime Minister Sheh-baz Sharif.

“The Deal with the Islamic Republic of Iran is now complete. Congratulations to all,” Trump said in a post on Truth Social on Sunday evening, easing pressure on the global energy markets.

He said the deal would reopen the Strait of Hormuz and end the US naval blockade on Iranian ports.

“I hereby fully authorise the toll-free opening of the Strait of Hormuz and, simultaneously, authorise the immediate



A man passes by a giant billboard that shows the late Iranian leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, center, and Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei, with Arabic writing that reads: “Thank you Iran”, in Dahiyeh, Beirut’s southern suburbs, Lebanon AP/PTI

removal of the United States Naval blockade. Ships of the World, start your engines. Let the oil flow!” Trump said.

However, in a subsequent

post, Trump said the Strait of Hormuz will open on Friday after the official signing of the agreement.

The finalisation of the deal,

on a day when Trump turned 80, capped a tumultuous week of war and diplomacy when the US carried out strikes on Iran and the US president, at the

last minute, backed off a threat to take control of the Kharg Island, the oil export hub of the Islamic Republic.

Continued on P4

BREAKTHROUGH

- » The Deal with the Islamic Republic of Iran is now complete. Congratulations to all: Trump
- » However, in a subsequent post, Trump said the Strait of Hormuz will open on Friday after the official signing of the agreement
- » ‘This Great Deal will bring Peace and Security to the whole Region. Many presidents have tried to make Peace with Iran, and all have failed before me’

» Iran’s deputy foreign minister Kazem Gharibabadi confirmed the agreement on state television but said Iran would not start implementing it until it was signed on Friday

Modi: Peace must prevail

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday welcomed the understanding reached between the United States and Iran on ending the conflict in West Asia, and hoped the implementation of the pact will help restore peace in the region and ensure the freedom of navigation.

“I welcome the understanding reached between the United States and Iran on ending the conflict in West Asia, which has caused serious economic disruption across the world and led to loss of life in many countries.

Continued on P4

India & Slovakia seal stronger ties



Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Prime Minister of Slovakia Robert Fico at Bratislava Castle, in Bratislava on Monday ANI

Defence, technology deals among 11 pacts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

BRATISLAVA: India and Slovakia on Monday elevated their ties to a comprehensive partnership and firmed up 11 agreements to expand the bilateral cooperation in a range of areas such as migration, digital technology and defence following talks between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his Slovak counterpart Robert Fico.

The two leaders also agreed to work towards the “earliest” implementation of the India-European Union free trade agreement that is expected to significantly shore up the bilateral economic engagement.

Modi is in Bratislava as part of his weeklong visit to Europe. It is the first visit to

BILATERAL BOOST

- » The two leaders also agreed to work towards the ‘earliest’ implementation of the India-European Union free trade agreement
- » Prime Minister Narendra Modi was conferred with Slovakia’s highest national award, The Order of the White Double Cross (1st Class). President of Slovakia Peter Pellegrini conferred the award on PM Modi at a ceremony in Bratislava

the European nation by an Indian prime minister.

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NDA govt focused on improving ordinary citizens’ quality of life in 12 years

PM Modi

In today’s paper

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SC: RTI activism has become new business

Refuses anticipatory bail to activist



NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday said that RTI activism has become a new business, while refusing to grant anticipatory bail to an activist and other accused of obstructing a public servant in road construction work. A bench of Justices Sandeep Mehta and Vijay Bishnoi denied bail to RTI activist Rakesh Kumar Behl and his aide, and questioned their authority to monitor the road construction work.

Justice Mehta observed, “RTI activism has become a new business. The Central government has issued funds, it will take care of the construction of the road. You are nobody. So-called RTI activist! Yellow journalism. Dismissed.”

Concurring with the views of Justice Mehta, Justice Bishnoi said, “Who are you to monitor the construction of all these roads? Are you some superior authority or what?”

Behl has challenged the Punjab and Haryana High Court’s order denying him anticipatory bail. His counsel contended that they had been falsely implicated in the case as they had highlighted the corruption involved in the road construction work.

According to the FIR, Behl along with another accused Rajiv Kumar alias Mintu allegedly obstructed the ongoing road construction work in Batala of Gurdaspur district of Punjab and also intimidated the complainant under whose supervision the work was being executed and the labourers present at the site.

They also used derogatory remarks against the labourer and inflicted injuries on the complainant. An FIR was registered against them under Sections 304(2), 132, 221, 121(1), 351(2), 351(3), of BNS, 2023 (Sections 3(5), 121(2) of the BNS, 2023 and

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CLIMBS FROM 8.26% IN APRIL

Fuel shock: WPI surges to 9.68% in May

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Wholesale price inflation shot up to a record 9.68 per cent in May, from 8.26 per cent in April, led by a sharp spike in prices of fuel and power, reflecting the impact of energy shocks emanating from the West Asia war.

The May wholesale price index (WPI)-based inflation is the highest in the current series with a base year of 2022-23.

The Commerce and Industry Ministry on Monday released the May WPI-inflation data, revising the base year to 2022-23, from 2011-12 earlier -- the

first revision in nine years.

The total number of items in the new WPI basket has increased from 697 to 957. New sources of energy, such as solar and wind, have been added under the ‘electricity’ group. In addition, nuclear electricity has been included in the basket.

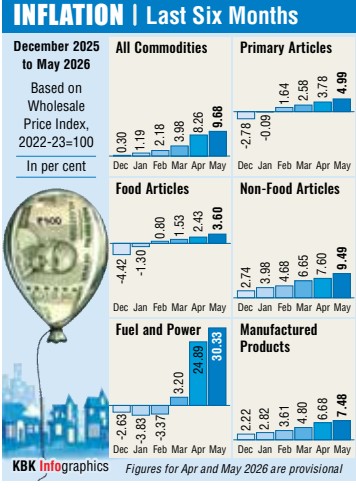
The ministry also released the producer price indices (PPI) for the first time to track output and input factory gate prices. Besides, Services PPI was released for seven services - Banking, Securities Transaction, Management of Pension Funds, Insurance, Railways, Air (Passenger), and Telecom.

The government intends to discontinue with WPI data in the next five years and shift to PPI, in alignment with the global best practice.

“Availability of both the Output PPI and Input PPI gives a better understanding of the price movements of output produced vis-a-vis inputs being used in an industry. It also explains how inflation experienced by producers on inputs is passed on to the output being produced,” the ministry said.

“Across groups, mineral oil (containing petroleum products), crude petroleum and natural gas,

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DUST FURY



Trucks remain parked as a dust storm sweeps across the area, in Churu, Rajasthan, on Monday PTI

Wind, rain tame Delhi heat

Wet conditions likely to persist for next two days

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Rain and strong winds hit the Capital on Monday as parts of the city received light to moderate rainfall, bringing some respite from the heat.

Squally winds were reported over Palam as the maximum wind speed reached 93 kmph in the afternoon, accompanied by pre-evening showers.

The brief spell of rain between 2.30 pm and 5.30 pm added to the moisture load. Palam recorded 9.0 mm of rainfall till 5.30 pm -- the highest in the region.

Ayanagar saw 4.6 mm



According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), Safdarjung logged a minimum temperature of 28.2 degrees Celsius, 0.7 notches above normal

rainfall, while Safdarjung and Lodi Road stations recorded trace amounts of rain, and

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UP’S JEWAR DREAM GETS WINGS; HISTORIC MOMENT, SAYS YOGI

Noida Airport’s first flyers: Farmers, workers

BISWAJEET BANERJEE/ DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: In an emotional moment marking the beginning of passenger services at Noida International Airport, around 170 farmers and workers whose land was acquired for the green-field project boarded the airport’s first outbound passenger flight to Lucknow on Monday.

The inaugural IndiGo flight departed for Lucknow at 8.30 am, carrying land donors, including women and elderly villagers, many of whom were experiencing air travel for the first time.

The passengers invited by the Uttar Pradesh government, met Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath in Lucknow. Officials said the



Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath with farmers during the commercial flight inauguration from Noida International Airport, Jewar PTI

gesture was aimed at recognising the role played by local communities in enabling the airport’s development.

The launch marked the cul-

mination of a journey that began over six years ago when thousands of acres of agricultural land were acquired for what has become India’s newest interna-

tional airport. For many passengers, the occasion was deeply emotional as they took off from land they once cultivated.

“We are extremely happy

to travel on the first flight from Noida International Airport to Lucknow. What we once imagined has become a reality,” said Abrar Khan,

Continued on P4

CLOSER LOOK

- » The inaugural IndiGo flight departed for Lucknow at 8.30 am, carrying land donors, including women and elderly villagers, many of whom were experiencing air travel for the first time
- » The passengers invited by the Uttar Pradesh government, met Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath in Lucknow
- » Officials said the gesture was aimed at recognising the role played by local communities in enabling the airport’s development

CJP founder slapped at Jaipur protest

MPOST BUREAU

JAIPUR: Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke was allegedly slapped multiple times by two men while supporters carried him on their shoulders during a protest here on Monday, police said.

Two youths have been detained in connection with the incident, they said.

Following the incident, Dipke addressed the gathering and raised slogans against divisive politics, urging people not to be divided along religious or caste lines.

Later, in a video message on X, the CJP chief alleged that this (attack on him) is a tactic by those who want to “disrupt our movement.”

“But we cockroaches will not be intimidated by these tactics. (Union Education Minister) Dharmendra Pradhan will have to resign...this is our only aim,” he said.

“Don’t get distracted. Dharmendra Pradhan Must Resign!” he also wrote on X.

According to police and eyewitnesses, the incident occurred at Shaheed Smarak where a number of youths had gathered to protest over issues such as the alleged NEET paper leak, CBSE marking system, and unemployment.

As Dipke arrived at the venue and was being carried on supporters’ shoulders, two youths in the crowd allegedly slapped him. His supporters later caught hold of the accused and assaulted them before the police intervened.

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CENSUS PHASE 1

2.3 cr people, 76L houses, 55L households recorded in Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The first phase of Census 2027 in Delhi, which concluded on June 14, covered nearly 76 lakh houses and around 55 lakh households, with enumerators recording that more than 2.3 crore people were ordinarily residing in the city, officials said.

According to provisional data from the House Listing Operations (HLO), enumerators covered 75,98,982 census houses and 54,98,560 households across Delhi's 13 districts.

The exercise was carried out through 45,863 House Listing Blocks (HLB). One HLB consists of around 180 houses.

In the first phase, 2,30,78,796 people were found to be normally residing in Delhi. Officials stressed that the population figure is provisional and based on the first phase of the census.

The final population count will emerge only after the second phase, which is Population Enumeration, scheduled for February 2027.

Among the districts, the North East recorded the high-



est population at 28,68,949, followed by the South West at 25,00,195, the West at 24,42,346 and the South East at 22,70,778.

The East district accounted for 21,66,251 residents, while the North West had 20,63,964 and Outer North 19,15,700.

North district recorded a population of 17,02,900, Central North 11,31,599 and Central district 9,60,798. Old Delhi had 7,54,478 residents, while the South district recorded 20,55,909. The New Delhi district had the lowest population at 2,44,929.

The data also showed wide

variations in the number of households across districts. South West topped the list with 6,25,453 households, followed by North East with 6,13,828, West with 5,89,210 and East with 5,47,461 households.

The South East recorded 5,43,412 households and the South recorded 534,212, while the North West had 4,65,586 and the Outer North had 4,35,631. The North district accounted for 3,98,447 households and the Central North for 2,73,669.

The Central district had 2,44,816 households, Old

HIGHLIGHTS

- » In the first phase, 2,30,78,796 people were found to be normally residing in Delhi
- » Officials stressed that the population figure is provisional and based on 1st phase of census
- » The final population count will emerge only after the second phase

Delhi 1,63,785 and New Delhi 63,050 households. In terms of housing stock, the South West district recorded the highest number of census houses at 8,20,529, closely followed by West at 8,02,589 and North East at 8,04,962. The New Delhi district recorded the lowest number of census houses at 1,02,706.

The houselisting operations (HLO) were already concluded in the New Delhi district, covering New Delhi Municipal Council and Delhi Cantonment Board areas.

In the New Delhi district,

where houselisting was conducted from April 16 to May 15, around 63,000 households and 2.5 lakh persons were listed, officials said.

Officials said the House Listing Operations, the first phase of the census, involves preparing an inventory of buildings and houses and collecting information on household amenities and assets.

The second phase, Population Enumeration, will gather detailed demographic and socio-economic information and determine the final population figures for Delhi and the country. While the first phase indicates that over 2.3 crore people are ordinarily living in Delhi, officials said the definitive population figure will be available only after the completion of Population Enumeration in February 2027.

The 16th Indian census is being conducted in two phases: the House Listing and Housing Census, which commenced on April 1, 2026, and will continue until September, followed by the Population Enumeration phase scheduled for February 2027.

Man shot dead by 3 assailants

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A man was shot dead by three unidentified assailants in northeast Delhi's Dayalpur area on Monday evening, police said.

The victim, identified as Rashid, was allegedly fired upon by the assailants in Nehru Vihar before they fled the spot, they said.

Police said the incident was reported around 6.10 pm. A police team rushed to the scene after receiving information about the firing and learnt that Rashid had already been taken to Guru Teg Bahadur (GTB) Hospital by local residents and family members.

Doctors at the hospital declared him brought dead.

Preliminary investigation revealed that three assailants allegedly opened fire on Rashid and escaped immediately after the attack. The motive behind the killing is yet to be ascertained, police said.

A forensic team visited the crime scene and collected evidence. Police personnel also inspected the area and are examining available leads, including footage from nearby CCTV cameras.

A case has been registered at Dayalpur police station and further investigation



TAKEAWAYS

- » The victim, identified as Rashid, was allegedly fired upon by the assailants in Nehru Vihar before they fled: Cops
- » Incident was reported around 6.10 pm
- » A police team rushed to the scene after receiving information about the firing and learnt that Rashid had already been taken to Guru Teg Bahadur (GTB) Hospital

is underway. Multiple teams have been constituted to identify and apprehend the accused, police said.

Investigators have developed substantial leads in the case and are working to trace the suspects, police added.

Delhi Police bust Rs 1.56 crore cyber fraud racket

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Cyber Cell of Delhi Police has busted an online investment fraud racket linked to cybercrime transactions worth approximately Rs 1.56 crore and arrested two men accused of facilitating cybercriminals by operating mule bank accounts used to siphon off money obtained through online scams.

The case came to light following a complaint registered at the Cyber Police Station in Shahdara. The accused have been identified as Sadik (32), a resident of Moradabad district in Uttar Pradesh, and Javed Ansari (34), a resident of Amroha district in Uttar Pradesh. According to police, the duo played a key role in enabling cyber fraudsters to receive, transfer and conceal proceeds generated through online investment scams.

An e-FIR was registered on April 9 under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita after a woman from Delhi's GTB Enclave reported being cheated of Rs 21 lakh in an online investment fraud.

During the investigation, the complainant told police that she had come across a stock market investment advertisement on Telegram. After clicking on the link, she was added to a group where fraudsters posed as investment experts and promised high returns through supposedly safe investment opportunities.

Trusting their claims, she transferred a total of Rs 21 lakh. However, when she later attempted to withdraw her money and claim the promised returns, the fraudsters neither returned the funds nor paid any profits. She was subsequently blocked from the Telegram groups, leading her to realise she had been deceived. A dedicated team led by Inspector Ashwani Kumar carried out extensive technical analysis and surveillance. Acting on specific intelligence inputs, police conducted raids in Moradabad and Amroha, leading to the arrest of the two accused.

During interrogation, the accused allegedly admitted to knowingly providing and operating bank accounts used by cybercriminals to receive and route cheated money. Police recovered two mobile phones, incriminating WhatsApp chats, bank account credentials and related financial records.

Further investigation is underway to trace the money trail and identify other members of the fraud network.

Ggm: DNA test reveals twins via IVF share genetic mismatch; couple files complaint

NEW DELHI: A Delhi-based couple filed a police complaint after a DNA test allegedly revealed that their twin born through an IVF procedure shares no genetic connection with either parent, raising questions about embryo-handling protocols at the hospital.

Rahul Rathore, 41, a builder by profession and his wife Meenu, 39 -- who claimed that they were residing in Gurugram in fear as they raised serious questions at the fertility centre -- said they want only their children.

Rathore said based on a Delhi court order, an FIR was registered against the In-Vitro Fertilisation (IVF) centre at Greater Kailash police station on March 31.

"Besides this, the police are not taking any action and we are being pressured from all sides, but we will not rest until we get our children back," Rathore alleged in the complaint.

According to the complainant, the matter began in December 2024, when the

“Child's 1st DNA report showed paternal mismatch, 2nd showed that neither maternal nor paternal DNA matched any child”

couple consulted Dr Ritu Garg, who introduced them to Dr Manpreet Kaur for IVF treatment and thereafter referred them to SCI Hospital in New Delhi's Greater Kailash-I.

Further, they were introduced to Dr Shivani Sachdeva, the treating In-Vitro Fertilisation (IVF) specialist, he alleged.

On January 9 last year, as part of the IVF process, medical tests were conducted at SCI Hospital, with the doctors and staff assuring the couple that the entire procedure would be conducted ethically using only their biological material, Rathore said.

"On February 13, 2025, my wife's eggs and my sperm were collected by the hospital authorities. By taking custody of our biological material, the hospital and doctors were

entrusted with property of a special nature, thereby attracting a fiduciary duty," he claimed.

A laparoscopy procedure was performed on February 14 and in March, the hospital informed them that five embryos had been created, of which three were transferred into his wife's womb on May 14, he claimed.

Claiming that embryos created from their genetic material were "unlawfully removed" and embryos "not genetically related to them" were implanted, he said that pregnancy was confirmed on May 24 and on January 5 this year his wife delivered two female twins.

He said that he, along with his wife, were made to believe that both children were their biological offspring.

Rathore further said that due to serious medical inconsistencies, he and his wife developed suspicion and conducted two independent DNA tests on January 7 this year through DNA Labs India and DNA Forensics Laboratory.

The child's first DNA report showed paternal mismatch and the second showed that neither maternal nor paternal DNA matched any child.

The reports establish that his embryo has been illegally substituted and given to another person, he claimed.

"When we confronted Gaurav Rathi with the DNA reports and questioned the illegal exchange of our child, we were called to the hospital on January 7," Rathore said.

The couple alleged they were offered compensation and told not to pursue the matter. They claimed hospital staff threatened consequences if they approached authorities. Despite an FIR being registered on court orders, they alleged no action has been taken. PTI

Dozen patients evacuated after fire breaks out in Delhi hospital

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: More than a dozen patients were evacuated from the AS Hospital in south-west Delhi's Dabri after a minor fire broke out in its electrical meter and panel, Delhi Police said on Monday.

No injuries were reported in the incident, it said.

According to the Delhi Fire Service (DFS), a call regarding the fire at the AS Multi Kidney Hospital on Dabri-Palam Road was received at 10.25 pm on Sunday, following which three fire tenders were rushed to the spot.

Delhi Police said it received a call reporting the blaze at the Sagarpur police station at 10.27 pm, and by the time a team reached the spot, the hospital staff and firefighters had already extinguished the fire.

A preliminary inquiry indicated that a short-circuit triggered the fire.

"There were around 15 patients inside the hospital when the fire broke out. The hospital staff swiftly shifted all



the patients to safe locations and ensured their safety," a police officer said.

The fire caused chaos at the hospital, with people seen running around to save their lives.

Locals along with hospital staff, including nurses and doctors, helped douse the flames with fire extinguishers, police said.

"Patients rushed to save their lives as the back door of the hospital was locked. I also rushed to the spot and helped those inside the hospital," a local said.

"The back door of the hospital was locked. I got a hammer from my home, which a man present there used to break open the door to help people come out," he added.

The fire triggered brief

Locals along with hospital staff, including nurses and doctors, helped douse the flames

panic in the area after two major fire incidents claimed multiple lives in the capital recently.

On June 3, a deadly fire ripped through a bed and breakfast hotel at Hauz Rani in Malviya Nagar, killing 23 people, including several foreigners.

On June 13, a fire at a multi-storey building in Tughlakabad Extension killed three members of a family and injured eight others.

A 17-year-old girl and three others have been apprehended for their alleged involvement in the incident. They reportedly set a scooter parked inside the building ablaze to "teach a lesson" to a resident over a monetary dispute of around Rs 80,000, police said.



GOVERNMENT OF N.C.T. OF DELHI
DELHI FIRE SERVICE HEADQUARTERS
CONNAUGHT PLACE, NEW DELHI-110001

Public Notice

Kind attention: All owners/occupiers of following Categories of the building

Please be informed that the Government of National Capital Territory of Delhi have enacted Delhi Fire Service Act, 2007 (Delhi Act 2 of 2009) and Delhi Fire Service Rules 2010 w.e.f. 01.07.2010. In pursuance to the said Act and Rules, every owner/occupier of premises / building falling under the category defined under Rule 27 are required to provide fire prevention and fire safety measures as per National Building Construction Standards-2026 (Part-F) as prescribed under Rule 33. Further, they shall apply to Principal Director, Delhi Fire Service for issuance of "Fire Safety Certificate" as per provision contained in Rule 35. The following classes of occupancies for the purposes of sub-section (1) of section 25 of the Act are required to obtain "Fire Safety Certificate" from Delhi Fire Service:

1. Residential buildings (other than hotels and guest houses) having height more than 15 meters or comprised of Five or more stories, including mezzanine/stilt floor above ground level.
2. Hotels and guest houses building having height more than 12 meters or comprised of four or more stories, including mezzanine/stilt floor above ground level.
3. Educational buildings having height more than 9 meters or comprised of three or more stories, including mezzanine/stilt floor above ground level.
4. Institutional buildings having height more than 9 meters or comprised of three or more stories, including mezzanine/stilt floor above ground level.
5. All Assembly buildings.
6. Business buildings having height more than 15 meters or comprised of five or more stories, including mezzanine/stilt floor above ground level.
7. Mercantile buildings having height more than 9 meters or comprised of three or more stories, including mezzanine/stilt floor above ground level.
8. Industrial buildings having covered area on all stories more than 250 square meters.
9. Storage buildings having covered area on all stories more than 250 square meters.
10. All Hazardous buildings having covered area on all stories more than 100 square meters.
11. Underground Structures comprising of two or more Levels.

Further the "Fire Safety Certificate" issued under Rule 35, unless sooner cancelled, shall be valid for a period of 5 years for residential buildings (other than hotels) and 3 years for non-residential building including hotels from the date of issue. The buildings which are not having Fire Safety Certificate from this department, are hereby requested to submit an application for obtaining Fire Safety Certificate for their respective occupancy. The application alongwith sanctioned/as built drawings through concerned building sanctioned authority in scale, are required to be forwarded to this department. In case your Fire Safety Certificate has expired, you can apply for renewal on the online portal for renewal of Fire Safety Certificate of this department.

DIAL: 101/112 IN CASE OF FIRE

Issued in the interest of Public Safety, by Principal Director, Delhi Fire Service

WE SERVE TOSAVE

**Principal Director
Delhi Fire Service**

DIP/Shabdarth/Classified/0110/26-27

Boy injured in stabbing incident in Narela; one held



OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A minor boy was injured after being stabbed in Delhi's Narela area, police said on Monday.

According to police, information was received from Raja Harish Chander Hospital regarding the admission of a boy with a stab injury on his chest.

"A police team immediately reached the hospital and initiated an inquiry into the incident," a senior police officer said.

The injured boy was later shifted to Lok Nayak Jai Prakash (LNJP) Hospital for further treatment.

During the course of the investigation, police apprehended one accused in connection with the case. The circumstances leading to the stabbing are being examined, and investigators are recording statements to ascertain the sequence of events. A case is being registered and further investigation is underway, police added.

Passport-style booklet to encourage students to explore 23 heritage sites

Programme likely to be rolled out after Aug 15

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NEW DELHI: In a first-of-its-kind initiative to encourage children to explore the capital's rich heritage, the Delhi government will introduce a passport-like booklet for students of Classes 4 to 6 featuring 23 monuments across the city, allowing them to collect stamps during visits and learn about city's history in an interactive manner.

The programme, being developed by the Delhi Tourism and Transport Development Corporation (DTTDC) in collaboration with the education department, is expected to be rolled out after August 15 and will run for six months. Students who complete visits to all 23 monuments and collect the required stamps will be eligible for awards and recognition from the tourism department, an official said.

"Imagine a Class 5 student carrying a small booklet resembling a real passport, complete with a photograph and personal details, setting out with family members on weekends to visit forts, tombs, stepwells and ancient structures scattered across the capital. At every monument, a stamp is added to the booklet, slowly filling its pages with memories of places that have

stood witness to Delhi's many rulers, empires and transformations," the official said.

The booklet, modelled on a travel passport, will carry a student's photograph and basic details on the opening page. The remaining pages will feature 23 monuments across Delhi along with brief descriptions and designated spaces for stamps that children can collect during their visits, he said.

"The idea is to make heritage exploration exciting for children," the official said. Instead of viewing monuments only through textbooks, students will be encouraged to visit them, learn about their history and interact with the city's cultural landscape firsthand.

According to officials, children visiting any of the listed monuments will receive a stamp in their booklet.

Those who complete visits to all 23 sites during the campaign period will be eligible for recognition and awards from the tourism department.

The six-month programme will distribute heritage passports through schools. Students completing visits to all 23 sites, including museums, can submit their booklets and become eligible for prize money.



Massive Yamuna clean-up clears 116+ tonnes of waste

Thousands of volunteers join coordinated drive across 28 ghats

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: A massive citizen-led cleanup unfolded along the Yamuna on Sunday as thousands of Delhiites fanned out across 28 ghats, collecting over 116 metric tonnes of waste in what the Delhi government described as one of the capital's largest coordinated riverfront cleanliness drives.

According to the Delhi government, the campaign brought together volunteers, resident welfare associations (RWAs), NGOs, community groups and government officials in a large-scale effort aimed at cleaning the Yamuna and spreading awareness against indiscriminate dumping of waste into the river.

The drive covered Yamuna ghats, riverbanks, access roads and nearby public spaces. The collected waste was segregated and processed in accordance with prescribed environmental norms. Officials said general garbage and construction and demolition (C&D) waste were disposed of through des-



ignated channels, while pooja waste and damaged idols were handled separately using environmentally compliant methods. Green waste, including water hyacinth removed from the river, was sent to designated facilities for scientific processing.

The campaign was jointly undertaken by the Irrigation and Flood Control Depart-

ment, Public Works Department (PWD), Delhi Jal Board (DJB), Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) and the Revenue Department, with support from Delhi Police, DUSIB and the Health Department.

To facilitate the operation, the government deployed eight trash skimmers and weed harvesters, 28 boats equipped with trained operators and

TAKEAWAYS

- » The drive covered Yamuna ghats, riverbanks, access roads and nearby public spaces
- » Collected waste was segregated, processed in accordance with environmental norms
- » 'General garbage, construction and demolition waste were disposed of via designated channels, while pooja waste and damaged idols were handled separately'

safety gear, 28 JCB machines, 84 PWD maintenance vans, 28 horticulture vehicles and garbage collection vehicles. Ambulances were also stationed at each ghat.

Water, PWD, Irrigation and Flood Control Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said, "Yamuna is not merely a river; it is the cultural, spiritual, and emotional lifeline of Delhi. For

years, conversations around the Yamuna focused on what was wrong. Today, thousands of Delhiites came together to demonstrate what can be made right when citizens and government work hand in hand."

"The most inspiring sight today was not the machinery or the scale of operations, it was seeing children, youth, senior citizens, and volunteers standing shoulder to shoulder with a shared commitment to restore the dignity of the Yamuna," he added.

Emphasising the need for sustained efforts, the minister said, "Cleaning the Yamuna is not a one-day exercise. It is a long-term commitment. The government is working on multiple fronts, but lasting change will come only when every citizen considers the river their own responsibility."

The government reiterated its commitment to the rejuvenation of the Yamuna and appealed to citizens to continue supporting initiatives aimed at ensuring a cleaner and healthier river ecosystem.

CM Gupta reviews plan to plant 70 lakh saplings

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government is preparing for one of its largest plantation initiatives in recent years, with the city government planning to plant 70 lakh saplings under the 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam - Delhi Mega Plantation Drive 2026'. The campaign, which seeks to combine environmental action with mass public participation through a multi-phase programme, is also expected to witness the presence of senior national leaders, with Union Home Minister Amit Shah proposed to inaugurate a key phase of the drive.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday chaired a high-level review meeting at the Delhi Secretariat to assess preparations for the campaign. Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa and senior officials attended the meeting, where discussions focused on plantation targets, public participation, digital platforms and departmental responsibilities.

According to the government, the first phase of the campaign will commence with a digital launch on June 22. The e-Forest Green Drive Portal and the campaign's official video will be unveiled, alongside a public awareness



drive through digital and social media platforms. Outreach activities will continue until July 4 to engage educational institutions, religious bodies, resident welfare associations and other community groups.

"The spirit of the 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' campaign launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi will be carried forward in Delhi and developed into a large-scale public movement," Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said.

The second phase, scheduled for the first week of July, will focus on ridge restoration through plantation drives at locations including PBG Ground, Central Ridge, South Central Ridge and Nanakpura Ridge. Around 2.5 lakh saplings are proposed to be planted on a single day during this phase.

The third phase, planned

for mid-July, will feature a large-scale plantation event at Swarn Jayanti Park in Rohini, linked live with 51 locations across Delhi. The government said around 11,000 people are expected to participate simultaneously. The campaign is proposed to cover all 70 Assembly constituencies and 13 districts during the Seva Parv period.

Citizen participation will be facilitated through the e-Forest Green Drive Portal, where residents can register using basic details, book plantation slots, obtain free saplings, upload geo-tagged photographs after planting and receive a 'Paryavaran Rakshak' e-certificate signed by the Chief Minister.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said, "Vriksh Rathis will be deployed to ensure the success of the campaign." She said these mobile units would distribute free saplings at colonies, schools, colleges, RWAs and religious institutions while providing guidance on plantation activities.

Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa said, "The 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam - Delhi Mega Plantation Drive 2026' is not merely a plantation programme but a broad-based public movement aimed at making Delhi greener and environment-friendly."

DJB pilots real-time water quality monitoring system

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In an effort to strengthen oversight of Delhi's drinking water supply, the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) has begun testing an online water quality monitoring system in Gulmohar Park, a South Delhi locality that recently witnessed complaints of contaminated water.

The pilot project involves the installation of an analyser capable of continuously tracking key water quality indicators, including pH levels, total dissolved solids (TDS) and chlorine content. Officials say the technology is expected to help detect irregularities in real time and assist in identifying the source of contamination more quickly.

Malviya Nagar BJP MLA Satish Upadhyay said the initiative could be expanded to other parts of the capital if the trial proves effective.

Officials indicated that if the pilot delivers the desired results, similar systems may be deployed across the Capital

"This technology enables us to monitor important parameters such as pH, TDS and chlorine levels in the water supply network. Since underground pipelines make it difficult to immediately trace contamination, real-time analysers can help detect problems early and identify their source," Upadhyay said.

He added that the pilot has been introduced under a public-private partnership (PPP) model and the complete installation process is likely to be finished within a week.

The move follows complaints from Gulmohar Park

residents regarding the quality of drinking water supplied to the area. According to local residents' representatives, authorities acted swiftly after the issue was brought to their notice.

Gulmohar Park RWA president Atul Bal told media the problem first emerged nearly three weeks ago. "After residents approached the MLA's office, teams from both the Delhi Jal Board and the MLA's office worked closely to address the issue.

Multiple contamination points and related concerns were identified during the exercise, and the problem has now been resolved," he said.

Officials indicated that if the pilot delivers the desired results, similar systems may be deployed across Delhi to strengthen routine water quality checks, improve response time and minimise the risk of contamination in the city's distribution network.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Monday inaugurated an Aadhaar Seva Kendra (ASK) in Vikaspuri, adding a new Aadhaar service facility in West Delhi aimed at improving access to enrolment, demographic updates and biometric services.

The inauguration was attended by Transport, Health and IT Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh, West Delhi MP Kamaljeet Sehrawat, UIDAI officials and local residents. The centre has been established under the second phase of the Unique Identification Authority of India's (UIDAI) Aadhaar Service Centre expansion programme.

Speaking at the event, Sandhu said, "Aadhaar has become a vital pillar of India's Digital Public Infrastructure,



enabling transparent, efficient and inclusive delivery of public services to citizens." He said Aadhaar supports direct benefit transfers, financial inclusion and service delivery, and stressed the need for timely biometric updates for children to avoid future authentication issues.

CLOSER LOOK

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- » He said Aadhaar supports direct benefit transfers, financial inclusion and service delivery, and stressed the need for timely biometric updates for children to avoid future authentication issues

Singh said the new centre would make Aadhaar-related services more accessible for residents of West Delhi and nearby areas. "Our goal is to build an Aadhaar-enabled and digitally empowered Delhi where every citizen can seamlessly access essential government services," he said.

The minister said Aadhaar plays an important role in access to welfare schemes and healthcare services. He added that Aadhaar enrolment facilities are being integrated with birth registration services in MCD and NDMC institutions to facilitate enrolment of newborns at the time of registration.

He also urged parents to ensure timely biometric updates for their children.

According to UIDAI, the Vikaspuri facility takes the total number of operational Aadhaar Seva Kendras in Delhi to six. The centres collectively serve thousands of residents daily.

UIDAI officials said more than 4.5 lakh children between 5 and 17 years of age in Delhi have updated their biometrics since September 2025 under an ongoing biometric update campaign. The authority is also working to increase Bal Aadhaar coverage among children aged 0-5 years.

Officials said online appointment booking is available at all Aadhaar Seva Kendras in Delhi. Two additional centres, planned for Central Delhi and North-East Delhi, are currently in the final stages of operational planning.

JNU extends PG admission registration deadline till Jun 17

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) has extended the registration deadline for admissions to its Postgraduate (PG) and ADOP programmes for the academic session 2026-27 and introduced a one-time correction facility for candidates who have already submitted their applications.

According to an official notification issued by the uni-

versity on Monday, the online admission portal, which was originally scheduled to close on June 15, will now remain open on June 16 and June 17, giving aspirants an additional opportunity to complete the application process.

The university stated that fresh applications may be submitted by eligible candidates who were unable to apply within the original timeline.

In addition, candidates who have already completed their

University has also urged students to regularly check the official website and admission portal for updates registrations will be permitted to make corrections or modifications in their submitted application forms. The correction facility, however, will not

apply to certain personal details including the candidate's name, father's name, mother's name, and date of birth.

JNU clarified that the correction window is being provided as a one-time opportunity and that requests for further modifications after the closure of the portal on June 17 at 11:50 p.m. are unlikely to be entertained.

Applicants have been advised to carefully verify all details before final submission,

including programme preferences, category selection, eligibility criteria, and other relevant information to avoid discrepancies during the admission process.

The university has also urged students to regularly check the official website and admission portal for updates and further announcements related to admissions.

The notice was issued by the Office of the Deputy Registrar (Admissions), JNU.

Sandhu calls for accelerated work on Yamuna floodplains

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu has directed officials to intensify and fast-track ongoing interventions across the Yamuna floodplains to ensure the timely implementation of projects being undertaken by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA).

The directions were issued during a review meeting at the Yamuna Sports Complex, where the Lieutenant Governor assessed progress on Yamuna rejuvenation initiatives.

Describing the Yamuna as both Delhi's ecological lifeline and a critical urban resilience asset, he stressed that flood preparedness, river restoration, groundwater recharge and environmental sustainability must advance through an integrated, outcome-driven and time-bound approach.

Officials informed the Lieutenant Governor that restoration and riverfront development works have been completed across nearly 1,700 hectares of the Yamuna floodplains.

As part of these efforts, around 88,574 metric tonnes of construction and demolition waste and 4,998 metric tonnes of municipal waste have been removed.

Approximately 1,425 acres of floodplain land has also been reclaimed, restored and secured from encroachment.

The DDA's restoration programme has included the plantation of more than 0.7 million native trees and the introduction of over 10 million riverine grasses and wetland species across the floodplain ecosystem.

In addition, 35 wetlands with a combined water-holding capacity of nearly 1,420 million litres have been developed along the river corridor to strengthen groundwater recharge, enhance biodiversity and reinforce the floodplain's natural ability to mitigate flood impacts.

The Lieutenant Governor also reviewed plans to revive 32 historic ghats at Yamuna Bazar and directed officials to expedite approvals for phased restoration and redevelopment within six months.

Forest Dept asks agencies not to act on tree-felling notification after High Court stay

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Forest Department has directed government departments and civic agencies not to act on a June 6 notification that permitted the felling or pruning of trees in certain circumstances without prior approval, after the Delhi High Court stayed its operation.

In a circular, the department informed authorities that the court had ordered no action be taken under the notification until further directions. The notification had allowed immediate removal or pruning of trees obstructing roads, drains, railway tracks and Metro infrastructure, as well as dead or dangerous trees, with Tree Officers to be informed later. The High Court observed that the notification appeared to allow tree felling for developmental works without adequate safeguards or consideration of alternatives. The order has been circulated to agencies. MPOST

EV Policy: Delhi government may offer scrapping incentives for e-rickshaws, Gramin Sewa vehicles

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government may introduce a scrapping incentive for e-rickshaws registered between 2015 and 2022 and Gramin Sewa vehicles under its proposed electric vehicle policy, officials said on Monday.

The government had released the draft electric vehicle (EV) policy 2.0 in April, seeking comments and suggestions from the stakeholders, the auto industry and the public.

The draft policy did not have any scrapping incentives for these vehicles. However, in the final policy, there may be an incentive to switch to EVs for the owners of such vehicles, the officials said.

"A scrapping incentive of Rs 5,000 may be provided upon scrapping of an e-rickshaw (passenger) registered in Delhi between January 2015 and December 2022, based on the submission of

a certificate of deposit by an authorised scrapping facility. However, a final decision is yet to be taken in the matter," an official said.

Under the new policy, there is also a plan to cap the number of e-rickshaw permits at 2,50,000, a step to reduce congestion in the city.

According to sources, the government is also working on a specific e-rickshaw policy to deal with vehicle registrations,

charging facilities, designated routes and stands, and traffic management.

It is also planning to provide a scrapping incentive of Rs 15,000 to Gramin Sewa vehicles to make them switch to electric mode. Currently, these vehicles run on CNG.

Officials said the policy may be finalised within two weeks. Only EV models approved by a proposed committee would qualify for incentives. PFI

Min: Flood control measures in place

NEW DELHI: Flood Control Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Monday said all arrangements are in place to prevent a flood-like situation in Delhi during the monsoon.

After reviewing preparedness and inaugurating a flood control room in East Delhi, he said officials are monitoring the Yamuna and waterlogging-prone areas round the clock.

The government has also undertaken a city-wide drive to identify and address vulnerable locations. MPOST

MET FORECASTS WET WEEK

Western disturbance over northwest India brings squally winds, rainfall

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A fresh western disturbance over the Himalayas, coupled with moisture-laden monsoon winds, brought light to moderate rainfall over several parts of northwest India on Monday, while strong winds blew over vast stretches of Delhi-NCR and Rajasthan, triggering dust storms.

“There was a cyclonic circulation over Punjab, Haryana and nearby areas, which led to rain over Delhi. Moisture-laden southwesterly winds from the Arabian Sea also helped in the development of this weather activity. Because of the moisture and the cyclonic circulation, parts of Punjab, Haryana and Delhi received rain,” Mahesh Palawat of Sky-met Weather said.

Rain lashed Gurugram and parts of Haryana while squally



People stroll amid rain, in Shimla, on Monday

winds ushered a dust storm over Noida. The weather office has forecast rain and thunderstorms over isolated parts of western Uttar Pradesh, while eastern parts of the state are likely to remain dry.

Several places in Rajasthan experienced thunderstorms and light to moderate rainfall during the 24 hours till Monday morning. Khanpur in

Jhalawar district recorded the highest rainfall at 51 mm.

Thunderstorm and rainfall are likely to continue in Rajasthan this week under the influence of a western disturbance, the weather office said on Monday.

Parts of Bikaner, Jaipur, Bharatpur, Ajmer, Kota and Jodhpur divisions are expected to witness rainfall over the next

Highlights

» Several places in Rajasthan experienced thunderstorms and light to moderate rainfall during the 24 hours till Monday morning

» In Himachal Pradesh, a hailstorm lashed Shimla and adjoining areas on Monday afternoon

PTI

few days, accompanied by strong winds at 60 to 70 kmph.

In Himachal Pradesh, a hailstorm lashed Shimla and adjoining areas on Monday afternoon, with the weather office forecasting a wet spell in the state till June 21.

There are reports of damage to apple crop in Kinnaur district owing to hailstorm.

Light to moderate rainfall

took place in several parts of the state in the 24 hours since Sunday evening.

The Shimla meteorological centre has issued an alert for thunderstorm, lightning and gusts of 40-50 kmph at isolated places in Chamba, Kangra, Kullu and Mandi districts for Thursday and Friday (June 18 and 19).

Several parts of Uttarkhand too saw light to moderate rainfall in the 24 hours till Monday evening, with weather stations in Chakrata and Kanda logging 11.5 mm and 11.0 mm rainfall, respectively, while Mussoorie recorded 9.2 mm.

The weather office has cautioned of thunderstorms and gusty winds at 40-50 kmph over isolated places in Uttarkashi, Rudraprayag, Chamoli, Dehradun, Tehri, Almora, Bageshwar and Pithoragarh districts.

SC grants relief to inter-caste couple fearing honour killing

Stays High Court order on parents’ visit

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Coming to the aid of an inter-caste couple fearing “honour killing”, the Supreme Court on Monday stayed a Rajasthan High Court order allowing the woman’s parents to meet them, despite their apprehensions of any untoward eventuality.

A bench of Justices Ujjal Bhuyan and Arun Palli stayed the order on the plea of the couple, who were earlier granted protection by the top court after they complained of life threats from the woman’s relatives.

“We should not encourage these types of regressive elements. They are hounding the couple out there. This is not proper,” the bench observed as it stayed the high court order and posted the matter for hearing in July.

During the hearing, the counsel for the woman’s parents submitted that the high court only intended to facilitate



a meeting between her and her father and in no way meant to dilute the protection granted to the couple.

The couple’s counsel also complained that Rajasthan Police personnel were continuously stationed outside their residence and have been visiting their relatives with regard to cases registered against them.

“I have been protected, but the Rajasthan police are sitting at my home...,” the lawyer said.

The Rajasthan government’s counsel assured the bench that the police personnel stationed outside their house will no longer visit the couple.

The said statement was

recorded by the court, which sought the Rajasthan government’s response on the couple’s plea.

On April 30, the top court had recorded the submission of the Uttar Pradesh government that it will provide security to the couple.

“The standing counsel for the fourth respondent -- the state of Uttar Pradesh -- submitted that Uttar Pradesh Police personnel have visited the house of the second petitioner, which is the matrimonial house of the first petitioner, and have assured that all steps would be taken in the event of any exigency insofar as the safety and security of the petitioners are concerned,” the top court had recorded, while disposing of the plea in which the couple had sought protection, while apprehending honour killing.

The top court had allowed the couple to reside in the house of the man’s parents in Uttar Pradesh’s Baghpat.

MP train tragedy: Loco pilot, victims couldn’t see each other due to sharp curve, say officials

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MORENA: A day after four passengers were run over by a train after disembarking in Madhya Pradesh’s Morena, officials on Monday said the loco pilot and the victims failed to spot each other due to a blind curve on the rail route.

A 4-year-old boy and three women were killed when they jumped off the Khajuraho-Udaipur Intercity Express in panic following a false fire alarm and emergency chain pulling and were run over by the Patalkot Express on the adjacent tracks in Morena district on Sunday, as per officials.

“There is a big curve. The passengers standing on an adjacent track and the loco pilot of the approaching train could not spot each other in time,” North Central Railway’s Jhansi Divisional Railway Manager (DRM) Anirudh Kumar told PTI over the phone on Monday. “The loco pilot of the

Patalkot Express applied brakes after noticing people on the tracks, but by then it was too late,” Kumar said, citing the near-spot circumstances.

A railway employee patrolling near the site immediately rushed there after learning of the incident and relayed information to the railway authorities,

he said.

Kumar rushed to the spot to study the scene on Sunday, comforted the families of the deceased and ordered a probe headed by their senior divisional safety officer into the incident.

“The probe panel will have five to six heads of different

departments. “It has been asked to hand over its report as soon as possible,” he added.

Initial financial help has been given to the families of the deceased, and more assistance will be provided to them, the official said. “We are working on it,” he added.

According to Kumar, the

incident was triggered by rumours of a fire in the Khajuraho-Udaipur Intercity Express (19665), following which passengers pulled the emergency chain and the train came to a halt.

Four passengers -- three women and a four-year-old boy -- got off the train in panic and

moved onto an adjacent track, where they were struck by the Patalkot Express (20424), which was on way from Firozpur in Punjab to Seoni in Madhya Pradesh, he said.

The passengers apparently failed to notice the approaching train and were run over, resulting in their deaths.

From Page 1

The peace pen

“This Great Deal will bring Peace and Security to the whole Region. Many presidents have tried to make Peace with Iran, and all have failed before me,” Trump said. Details of the deal were not immediately available.

Iran’s deputy foreign minister Kazem Gharibabadi confirmed the agreement on state television but said Iran would not start implementing it until it was signed on Friday.

Pakistan, which has emerged as a key mediator in the US-Iran negotiations, facilitating contacts between Washington and Tehran and hosting diplomatic efforts aimed at ending the conflict, also confirmed the deal.

The deal was negotiated through mediators that included Pakistan and Qatar, who initially got a two-week ceasefire agreement on April 8. The ceasefire was extended till the completion of the talks.

The US and Israel launched attacks on Iran on February 28, killing Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and several top commanders. Khamenei’s son Mojtaba, who was elected as the new supreme leader, has not been seen in public since the war began.

Israel and Iran appeared to back away from further strikes Monday, hours after they traded fire for the first time since the US agreed to a ceasefire with Tehran two months ago. Both countries warned that they were ready to launch retaliatory attacks if provoked.

The renewed hostilities raised concerns that the Middle East could be plunged back into a full-scale war.

Since the US and Israel began striking Iran on February 28, the war has shaken the global economy, driven energy prices up around the world and made many basics, including food, more expensive. Officials have been unable to turn the April ceasefire into a deal to permanently end the conflict.

The new attacks prompted US President Donald Trump to call for an immediate stop to fighting between Israel and Iran.

Soon after, the Iranian military’s joint command issued a statement that said it was halting offensive strikes. The statement said further “aggression and hostile acts” by Israel and its supporters, including in southern Lebanon, would be met with “much more severe and crushing measures than before.”

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, speaking in a videotaped statement, implied that the current round of fighting was over. But he also warned that

if Iran “makes the mistake and returns to attacking us, we will respond with force.”

Netanyahu said Israel is continuing to operate in Lebanon against the Iranian-backed militant group Hezbollah, and that Israel “has full right to self-defence, and we will exercise it to the full extent necessary.”

Iran launched waves of attacks on Israel on Monday, and Israel launched strikes on central and western Iran.

Iranian state media reported at least 15 people were wounded after explosions sounded in Tehran and other cities. There were no immediate reports of fatalities.

The semiofficial Fars and Mehr news agencies said Israeli strikes hit a petrochemical factory in the city of Mahshahr. They did not elaborate on any damage. The Israeli military confirmed the strike on the plant, saying it targeted sites that produce materials for ballistic missiles. Israel said it also targeted truck-based missile launchers.

Israel’s defence minister said Monday that Israel won’t withdraw from land seized in Lebanon as the interim deal between Iran and the United States is pending.

Israel Katz’s remarks were the first official Israeli comments after the announcement of the interim deal. The two sides plan to meet Friday in Geneva to sign it, Pakistan has said.

Katz said Israel plans to stay “indefinitely” in lands it holds in Lebanon, as well as Syria and the Gaza Strip. Iran has tied the interim deal over the war to halting Israel’s attacks on Hezbollah in Lebanon.

Katz also threatened that if Iran attacks Israel over Israeli strikes in Lebanon, Israel will strike Iran with “great force.”

Over the past two and a half years, Israel has taken control of areas in Gaza, Lebanon, and Syria amounting to 1,000 square kilometres of territory — an area that is slightly smaller than New York City.

Modi

India hopes that the implementation of this understanding will help restore peace and stability in the region and ensure the freedom of navigation and commerce,” Modi said in a post on X.

The prime minister said India looks forward to deliberations on the remaining issues reaching a sustainable final agreement. MP05T

India & Slovakia

“We have decided to elevate our relations to the status of a Comprehensive Partnership. This symbolises our shared beliefs,

shared priorities, and shared future,” he said in his media statement.

The comprehensive partnership aims to take bilateral relations to a new level, strengthen existing cooperation mechanisms and explore new avenues for deepening cooperation, both bilaterally and multilaterally.

The prime minister said he and Fico discussed ways to give a “new direction” to the ties.

Modi and Fico also agreed to enhance cooperation in the energy sector with a view to promoting energy security, sustainability and resilience through diversification of energy sources, including nuclear energy and geothermal power.

“Our potential is vast. Our aspirations are even greater. Automobiles, railways, advanced manufacturing, and green technologies are areas of particular interest to us,” he said.

“Today, we combined our strengths on all these issues and took several important decisions for the benefit of the people of both countries.”

Modi also said that the defence cooperation between India and Slovakia is a testament to the “deep mutual trust and strategic convergence” between the two sides.

A Letter of Intent was finalised on defence cooperation following the talks between the two leaders.

The prime minister said it will give new momentum for cooperation between the defence industries of the two sides.

“India and Slovakia are also moving forward with close coordination on the global stage. We agree that all disputes and tensions should be resolved peacefully,” he said.

“We also agree that global institutions need to redefine themselves to address the realities and challenges of the 21st century. We will work to strengthen global efforts in this regard,” he added.

Modi also conveyed his appreciation to PM Fico for the cooperation Slovakia extended in finalising the India-EU free trade agreement.

“We will work towards its earliest implementation so that industries, startups, and traders of both countries can derive maximum benefit from it,” he said.

In his remarks, PM Fico hailed the India-EU FTA, describing it as one of the “most ambitious” trade pacts ever signed.

“Slovakia not only welcomes this agreement, but it will take the necessary and practical steps for the implementation of this agreement,” he said.

The agreements inked following Modi-Fico talks are set to provide for deeper bilateral cooperation in areas of labour migration, defence, digital technologies, higher education and quantum communication.

In the meeting, the two leaders, recognising the growing

geopolitical, economic and technological importance of the Indo-Pacific, acknowledged the value of a stronger partnership between India and Slovakia in support of mutually beneficial cooperation, regional connectivity, open international trade, freedom of navigation, and peaceful resolution of disputes, according to a joint statement.

Modi and Fico expressed support for the orderly, safe and legal mobility of skilled professionals and welcomed the signing of the Memorandum of Understanding on cooperation in the field of labour migration to facilitate mobility.

The two sides also agreed to work towards the early conclusion of a Social Security Agreement, which would contribute to safeguarding the welfare and social protection of working professionals engaged in mobility between India and Slovakia.

The statement said Modi and Fico supported comprehensive reforms of multilateral institutions, particularly the UN Security Council. In this context, India appreciated Slovakia’s continued support for India’s permanent membership in a reformed and expanded UN Security Council.

Fuel shock

manufacture of chemicals and chemical products, and manufacture of basic metals have been major drivers of WPI inflation in April and May 2026,” the Commerce ministry said.

The fuel and power segment, which now accounts for 14.1 per cent of the WPI by weight and also includes the crude petroleum and natural gas groups, witnessed a sharp rise in the inflation rate to 30.33 per cent in May, from 24.89 per cent in April 2026, reflecting the continued passthrough of elevated global energy prices.

Inflation in crude petroleum was 61.51 per cent in May, as against 56.31 per cent in the previous month.

The sharp rise in WPI inflation reflects the impact of the West Asia crisis and the effective blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, through which the majority of the crude oil is imported to India, and its spillover effect on food prices.

Inflation in food articles was 3.60 per cent in May, compared to 2.43 per cent in April. In manufactured products, inflation rose to 7.48 per cent in May, from 6.68 per cent during April, data showed.

ICRA Principal Economist Rahul Agrawal said the recent cooling in global energy and commodity prices after the easing of tensions in West Asia is expected to provide respite to the WPI inflation print for June 2026.

Wholesale inflation continued to be much higher than the retail or consumer price index based inflation for the second consecu-

tive month. Retail inflation had surged to a 16-month high of 3.93 per cent in May, as against 3.48 per cent in the previous month.

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI), which mainly factors in CPI when arriving at its monetary policy, has been mandated by the government to ensure that headline inflation remains at 4 per cent, with a 2 per cent margin on either side.

Earlier this month, the RBI raised its inflation projection for the current fiscal year to 5.1 per cent from 4.6 per cent, largely due to mounting input costs, driven by the pass-through of higher global energy prices to retail petrol and diesel prices. Rising global crude oil prices had led to a Rs 7.50-a-litre increase in petrol and diesel prices in the second half of May.

Meanwhile, the government came out with producer price index (PPI) data for both goods and services for the first time to better reflect price movement, paving the way for phasing out wholesale price inflation numbers in the next five years.

This is in line with practices adopted by advanced economies and the recommendations of the International Monetary Fund (IMF), which stressed that there is a growing need for India to transition from the wholesale price index (WPI) to the Producer Price Index (PPI). WITH AGENCY INPUTS

PM’s 100th

minister on May 26, 2014, and was re-elected in 2019 and 2024.

So far, Modi has travelled to 78 countries as prime minister in his 12-year tenure, according to the PMO website.

In his first term, the prime minister altogether undertook 49 foreign tours.

During his second term, Modi’s first foreign visit was to the Maldives and Sri Lanka from June 8 to 9, 2019.

Modi undertook a total of 27 foreign trips in his second term.

In his third term, Modi’s first foreign visit was to Italy, which was from June 13 to 14, 2024.

His last foreign tour was to the UAE, Netherlands, Sweden, Norway and Italy from May 15 to 20 this year.

The prime minister’s ongoing foreign tour, which began on June 13 and will conclude on June 18, is the 24th in his third term so far.

In this trip, Modi is visiting France and Slovakia, during which he will attend the G7 Summit and have discussions with world leaders on various bilateral and global issues.

Wind, rain

Safdarjung, the city’s case station, logged a maximum of 37.5 degrees Celsius, a notch below

normal.

Palam also recorded 37.5 degrees Celsius, while Lodi Road and Ayanagar registered 37.8 degrees Celsius and 38 degrees Celsius, respectively.

The maximum temperature was recorded at 38.8 degrees Celsius at the Ridge observatory -- the highest among all stations.

Weather officials said day temperatures were largely near normal, with a departure of minus 1.3 degrees Celsius at Safdarjung and minus 1.7 degrees Celsius at Palam. However, the 24-hour change in maximum temperatures remained marginally negative across most stations, indicating slight cooling due to rain.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), Safdarjung logged a minimum temperature of 28.2 degrees Celsius, 0.7 notches above normal.

The minimum temperature was lower at Palam, which recorded 25.4 degrees Celsius, while Lodi Road and Ridge stations registered 26 degrees Celsius and 25.5 degrees Celsius, respectively. Ayanagar recorded a minimum of 26.6 degrees Celsius.

“There was a cyclonic circulation over Punjab, Haryana and nearby areas, which led to rain over Delhi. Moisture-laden southwesterly winds from the Arabian Sea also helped in the development of this weather activity. Because of the moisture and the cyclonic circulation, parts of Punjab, Haryana and Delhi received rain,” Mahesh Palawat of Sky-met Weather said.

He further said the activity is likely to continue for the next two days, although its intensity will reduce gradually. “Since there is still moisture in the air, temperatures are not expected to rise significantly during this period. After that, temperatures are likely to start increasing again,” he said.

For Tuesday, the weather office has forecast thunderstorms with rain, with minimum and maximum temperatures expected to be around 27 and 38 degrees Celsius, respectively.

The Air Quality Index (AQI) was recorded at 151, in the ‘moderate’ category, at 4 pm on Monday, according to Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) data.

According to the CPCB, an AQI between zero and 50 is considered ‘good’, 51 to 100 ‘satisfactory’, 101 to 200 ‘moderate’, 201 to 300 ‘poor’, 301 to 400 ‘very poor’, and 401 to 500 ‘severe’

CJP founder

Videos of the incident have gone viral on social media.

The police said that one of the detained accused, identified as Rakesh Gurjar, claimed he was a nationalist while alleging that Dipke has a ‘Jihadi’ mindset and is misleading people. Gurjar said that paper leak is just an excuse.

Reacting to the incident, CJP spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka alleged that Rajasthan has, in recent times, become a major centre for paper leaks.

He said the state, which produces many IITians and chartered accountants, is now witnessing a decline of its education system.

Noida Airport

one of the passengers invited for the historic journey.

Hera Rashid, a resident of a nearby village, described the experience as unforgettable. “We are travelling on the first flight free of cost and will meet the Chief Minister in Lucknow. This is a memorable day for all of us,” she said.

A 72-year-old farmer from Kishorepur village said he never imagined he would one day fly from an airport built on his former farmland. Another farmer, who had given 30 bighas of land for the project, said witnessing the airport become operational was a matter of immense pride.

Earlier in the morning, the airport welcomed its first incoming commercial flight from Lucknow at 8.05 am. Uttar Pradesh Assembly Speaker Satish Mahana arrived on the flight and was received by airport officials. The aircraft later continued onward to Bengaluru after boarding passengers.

Jewar MLA Dharendra Singh said the inaugural flight was a tribute to the farming families who sacrificed their ancestral land for development. “The hands that once tilled these fields are now holding boarding passes and touching the skies,” he said.

Developed in Jewar in Gautam Buddh Nagar district, Noida International Airport is expected to emerge as a major aviation, logistics and cargo hub for north India. Its launch is being seen as a significant boost to regional connectivity, trade and economic growth in western Uttar Pradesh, while the first flight served as a reminder of the local communities whose contribution made the project possible.

Calling the commencement of commercial flights a historic moment, Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath said Jewar, once lacking basic infrastructure despite its proximity to Delhi, was now poised to emerge as a major economic hub.

“Now think about it, you are going to outshine Delhi,” he told the farmers.

SC: RTI

Section 3(1) of the SC/ST Act. The Punjab and Haryana High Court in its order on May 14 said that the allegations levelled in the FIR disclose specific and direct involvement in obstructing the government work and refused to grant them anticipatory bail.

SET TO BE OBSERVED ON JUNE 21

PM to lead Yoga Day main event in Kolkata

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi will lead the main event of the International Day of Yoga in Kolkata on June 21, Union Minister for Ayush Prataprao Jadhav said here on Monday.

Addressing a press conference, Jadhav said this year's theme, 'Yoga for Healthy Ageing', highlights the role of yoga in promoting physical health, mental well-being and healthy ageing.

"This year's main event of the International Day of Yoga will be held on Kolkata's historic Red Road under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi," he said.

Jadhav said that International Day of Yoga (IDY) is receiving unprecedented support across the globe and yoga events will be held in nearly 2,500 locations worldwide.



"Under the visionary leadership of Prime Minister Modi, Yoga has evolved into a global mass movement and millions of people across the world have embraced yoga as an integral part of their daily lives," the minister said.

This year's theme addresses one of the most significant needs of our time. Yoga plays a vital role in enabling people to lead healthy, active, self-reliant, and mentally resilient lives as

they age, he said.

Highlighting the growing international outreach of the movement, the minister said that in coordination with the Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR), more than 210 Indian missions abroad will organise yoga events at nearly 2,500 locations across the world.

"This reflects how yoga has transcended its origins as India's cultural heritage to become a shared global

movement for health and well-being," he said.

"Across the world, people are living longer than ever before. The real challenge, however, is to ensure that these added years are healthy, active, independent and meaningful.

"Yoga offers a time-tested and holistic pathway towards healthy ageing by strengthening physical health, promoting mental well-being and enhancing overall quality of

life," the minister said.

He also announced a major milestone achieved in the run-up to IDY 2026. Referring to the special nationwide live yoga session organised on June 14, Jadhav stated that more than four lakh participants joined simultaneously, creating a new Guinness World Record.

He further said that the Ministry of Culture will organise special International Day of Yoga events at 100 locations across the country, bringing together India's rich cultural heritage and yoga traditions.

He also highlighted the successful organisation of countdown events held over the past few months, including the 100-day countdown in Delhi, the 75-day event at Lonar in Maharashtra, the 50-day programme at Kanha Shanti Vanam in Hyderabad and the 25-day countdown

celebration at Khajuraho.

Jadhav also talked about the ongoing 'Gangotri to Gangasagar: Ganga Tat Yoga Yatra' being organised from June 13 to 20.

Covering locations including Gangotri, Haridwar, Varanasi, Patna, Hooghly and Gangasagar, the initiative seeks to connect yoga with environmental stewardship, river culture and community participation.

The minister said that Kolkata will host a series of special programmes ahead of the main event. On June 19, the city will witness the 'Doud se Dhyani' programme promoting the link between physical fitness and mental wellness.

On June 20, celebrations including 'Vande Yogam' and West Bengal Day observances will showcase the harmonious blend of yoga, patriotism and cultural heritage.

Union Home secretary reviews preparedness for NEET(UG) re-exam

Students' convenience, security in focus

OUR CORRESPONDENT

TAKEAWAYS

» Throughout the discussion, focus rested on tight collaboration across departments to maintain clarity, order, and safety during the exam

» The integrity of the exam process must hold firm, stated the Home secretary, who stressed precise implementation across every operational level

NEW DELHI: The Union Home secretary on Monday chaired a high-level review meeting to assess the preparedness of state governments and Central agencies for the upcoming NEET (UG) re-examination 2026, with a special focus on student convenience, security arrangements and ensuring the integrity of the examination process.

The meeting was attended by the Chairman of the Railway Board, senior officials from the Departments of School Education and Higher Education, the Department of Posts, the National Testing Agency (NTA), the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, and the Ministry of Defence. Representatives from the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) and the Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS) also participated.

Throughout the discussion, focus rested on tight collaboration across departments to maintain clarity, order, and safety during the exam. With precision expected, each state administration, union region, and federal body was asked to follow established safeguards carefully. Prevention of disruptions became a shared priority under these guidelines.

Attention focused on easing travel for those retaking the exam. To assist them, state and union territory authorities received guidance - smooth transit to test sites became a priority. Support systems emerged quietly alongside these efforts. Where movement mattered most, arrangements followed without delay.

The integrity of the exam process must hold firm, stated

the Home secretary, who stressed precise implementation across every operational level. While public trust stands central, each logistical detail requires careful oversight to prevent missteps. With accuracy in administration seen as essential, uniform adherence to protocol becomes unavoidable.

Full assistance will be provided by the Chairman of the Railway Board toward meeting candidate travel needs. Logistics required for smooth transit will follow without delay. Support remains aligned with operational necessities. Movement facilitation stands confirmed under coordinated arrangements. The process has been shaped by the Centre's focus on delivering the NEET-UG Re-examination 2026 without disruption, where safety measures support trust. Though unseen, careful planning underlies how fairness reaches every candidate nationwide. Confidence grows not through claims but consistency in execution. Security forms one layer; transparency adds another.

Each step follows structured oversight rather than improvisation. Across regions, conditions align to reduce variation.

SC stays HC proceedings on pleas challenging new transgender law

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday stayed further proceedings before the High Courts on petitions challenging the provisions of the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Act, 2026.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice V Mohana agreed to hear the Centre's petition seeking to consolidate and transfer all pending pleas challenging the Act from various high courts to the apex court.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre, told the bench that the issue relates to constitutional validity of a central Act.

"Issue notice," the bench said, adding, "further proceedings before the high courts



shall remain stayed". On May 27, Mehta had mentioned the matter before the top court and sought an urgent listing of the transfer petitions.

The top law officer had said that since multiple high courts were currently seized of the matter, there was a significant risk of "divergent views" and conflicting judicial rulings on the validity of the federal legislation. The Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Act, 2026,

has come under intense legal scrutiny from human rights activists and members of the LGBTQ+ community. The primary bone of contention is the removal of the concept of "self-identification" of gender, a right previously upheld by the Supreme Court in its landmark NALSA judgment.

The 2026 Amendment reportedly mandates medical or administrative interventions for gender recognition, which the petitioners argue violates the right to dignity, privacy, and bodily autonomy.

On May 4, the apex court had sought responses from the Centre and others on separate pleas challenging the validity of the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Act, 2026.

NCERT to restore original image of 'Dancing Girl' in Class 9 book

NEW DELHI: The National Council of Educational Research and Training will replace the modified image of the iconic "Dancing Girl" figurine of Mohenjo-daro in its Class 9 Arts textbook with the original version, following criticism over the 'clothed' depiction of the artefact.

The move comes as a debate erupted over the representation of one of the most recognisable archaeological artefacts from the Indus Valley Civilisation in school textbooks.

Asked whether the NCERT will replace the retouched image of the 'Dancing Girl' in the Class 9 Arts textbook with the original version, its Director Dinesh Saklani replied in the affirmative.

The bronze figurine --

The move comes following criticism over the 'clothed' depiction of the iconic artefact

"Dancing Girl" of Mohenjo-daro -- was depicted with its bare torso covered in the opening chapter, "History of Arts", of Madhurima, NCERT's new Class 9 Arts education textbook.

In the version carried in the textbook, the torso of the figurine appears visually altered compared to the photographs of the original artefact, with shading used across the upper body that obscures anatomical details visible in the sculpture.

Manipur: 3 injured in firing in Kangpokpi

IMPHAL: At least three persons were injured in an exchange of fire between two groups in Manipur's Kangpokpi district on Monday, officials said.

The firing took place near Leilon Vaiphei village around 6 am when armed persons belonging to two tribal communities exchanged fire in the Kuki-majority district, they said. The injured, all belonging to the Kuki community, were brought to the Regional Institute of Medical Sciences (RIMS) in Imphal for treatment by security forces.

They were identified as Genlenmang Vaiphei (18), Lunliandaw Vaiphei (20) and Paogou Lal (18), officials said. Meanwhile, security has been tightened at the hospital complex.

Rohtak fire: CM Saini announces Rs 10L each for kin of deceased

ROHTAK: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Monday visited the D-Park market area here, where June 9 fire claimed three lives and engulfed several shops, and announced financial assistance of Rs 10 lakh each for the families of the deceased.

He also stated that establishments which suffered heavy losses in the fire would receive immediate financial assistance from the Chief Minister's Relief Fund. Saini said here that according to preliminary information, the fire was caused by a short circuit in an air conditioner, which rapidly escalated and engulfed several establishments.

He stated that the government stands with the families and traders affected by the devastating fire. While acknowledging that no compensation



Haryana CM Nayab Saini consoles family members of Rohtak blaze victims

can replace the loss of human life, he assured that the state government would extend every possible support to the victims and affected business owners. The CM announced an immediate financial assistance of Rs 5 lakh from the fund for those whose shops were damaged in the fire, while an amount ranging between Rs 50,000 and Rs 2 lakh was announced for the street vendors and small traders.

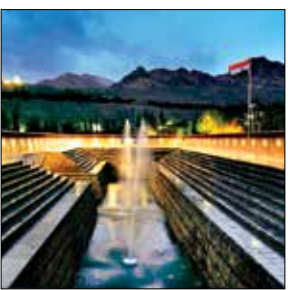
The CM said that the Urban Local Bodies Department is assessing the losses and based on the report, the state government will take further decisions regarding additional assistance and compensation. He noted that the market is an old commercial area and emphasised the need for greater vigilance to prevent such incidents. Saini also visited the residences of the three persons who lost their lives in the incident.

L-G inaugurates rejuvenated T-Trench water body in Leh

LEH: In a significant step towards strengthening drinking water security in Ladakh, Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Monday inaugurated the rejuvenated T-Trench Water Body at Spang-Jung in Gompa village near Leh.

The restored spring-fed water source is expected to benefit nearly 2,000 residents by improving water availability and groundwater recharge. Officials said the project has increased the source's discharge capacity from about 3 lakh litres per day to 5 lakh litres per day, substantially enhancing the area's drinking water supply.

Built in the 1980s, the T-Trench once served as the sole drinking water source for Leh city. However, rapid urbanisation and unplanned develop-



ment led to its gradual decline. After taking charge as Lieutenant Governor on March 13, Saxena directed officials to restore the historic water body on a mission mode.

The rejuvenation included removal of accumulated silt and debris, construction of eco-friendly gabion stone masonry structures to aid groundwater recharge, and installation of modern filtration systems to ensure safe drinking water. The

site has also been developed into a public space.

On the occasion, Saxena said the rejuvenation of the T-Trench reflects Ladakh's long-standing tradition of respecting and conserving water resources. He noted that the Union Territory is increasingly experiencing the effects of climate change, including reduced snowfall, receding glaciers, rising temperatures and declining groundwater levels.

He stressed the need for sustainable water management practices, preservation of traditional water systems, and development of new mechanisms for water harvesting and conservation. The Lieutenant Governor said the project aligns with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision for water conservation under the Jal Jeevan Mission.

CISF expands maritime security role, to assess 27 port facilities in 2026-27

Expands training programmes for stakeholders involved in port security

NARESH BISWANI

KEY POINTS

» The CISF was granted the status of a Recognised Security Organisation (RSO) under the International Ship and Port Facility Security (ISPS) Code on May 6, 2026

» The designation authorises the force to conduct Port Facility Security Assessments (PFSA) and prepare Port Facility



Security Plans (PFSPs) for 264 port facilities across the country

NEW DELHI: The Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) is expanding its role in maritime security as India strengthens protection of its coastline and critical port infrastructure amid growing economic activity in the maritime sector.

In a significant development, the CISF was granted the status of a Recognised Security Organisation (RSO) under the International Ship and Port Facility Security (ISPS) Code on May 6, 2026. The designation authorises the force to conduct Port Facility Security Assessments (PFSA) and prepare Port Facility Security Plans (PFSPs) for 264 port facilities across the country.

As part of the initial implementation phase during 2026-27, the CISF is scheduled to undertake security assessments of 27 major and minor ports engaged in export and import operations.

To strengthen its maritime security capabilities, the force has partnered with institutions

including the Rashtriya Raksha University, Indian Register of Shipping and Indian Maritime University. These collaborations are aimed at developing specialised expertise and creating an in-house pool of maritime security professionals.

According to officials, 45 CISF officers have already been certified in advanced maritime security training, while another 90 personnel are undergoing specialised RSO courses. Upon completion of the programme, the force will have around 135 qualified maritime security consultants capable of independently conducting security assessments and providing

advisory services at ports across the country. The CISF has also expanded training programmes for stakeholders involved in port security. So far, 2,123 personnel from private security agencies have completed specialised port security courses. In addition, 124 officials from government agencies, including Coastal Police units and other regional security organisations, have undergone training under the new framework.

The force has also introduced a dedicated security framework for fishing harbours, fish landing centres and smaller waterfront facilities. New guidelines are being devel-

oped to enhance surveillance, strengthen regulatory compliance and improve coastal security oversight. Officials said that if the proposed Bureau of Port Security is established under the Merchant Shipping Act, 2025, the CISF could assume a larger role in security assessments, policy formulation, advisory services and training.

With Indian ports becoming increasingly important for trade, logistics, energy supply chains and tourism, the CISF's expanded maritime mandate is expected to play a key role in safeguarding critical coastal infrastructure while supporting the country's economic growth.

BISWAJET BANERJEE

AYODHYA: What began as whispers about the lavish lifestyles of a handful of temple employees has snowballed into one of the biggest alleged financial scandals involving a Ram Temple in Ayodhya. Investigators now suspect that the alleged misappropriation of cash offerings made by devotees at the Ram Temple could exceed Rs 200 crore, making it one of the country's largest alleged thefts of religious donations.

The Uttar Pradesh government has constituted a Special Investigation Team (SIT) to probe the case, while a senior IPS officer from Delhi is also conducting a parallel inquiry. The SIT has been directed to submit its report within 15 days.

Nearly 50 people associated with the counting of donations have come under scrutiny. So far, investigators have recovered around Rs 2 crore in cash, an SUV and three iPhones from five suspects. Officials believe further recoveries are likely as they trace financial transactions and examine assets accumu-

Nearly 50 people associated with the counting of donations have come under scrutiny

lated over the past five years.

According to sources, suspicions first arose after several members of the donation-counting team displayed a sudden rise in wealth. Investigators are examining purchases of expensive vehicles, land parcels, commercial establishments and residential properties allegedly acquired by employees and their relatives despite modest salaries.

Cash offerings deposited by devotees in donation boxes are transported to a high-security room within the Ram Janmabhoomi complex, where they are counted by private employees under the supervision of trust personnel. Representatives of the State Bank of India and auditors are also involved in the process.

Among those under the scanner is Ram Shan-

kar Yadav alias Tinnu, who is alleged to have amassed assets worth nearly Rs 50 crore in Ayodhya and Lucknow. Investigators are examining properties, hospitality ventures and vehicles reportedly linked to him. His nephew, Manish Yadav, is also being questioned, with sources claiming Rs 36 lakh in cash was recovered based on information obtained during the investigation.

Other members of the counting team, including K.D. Tiwari, Rajesh Pathak, Lavkush and Anukalp Mishra, are also being investigated over assets and expenditures that investigators believe may be disproportionate to their known sources of income. Cash recoveries and property transactions linked to some of the suspects are being verified.

Officials say the probe will determine whether donations were systematically diverted over the years and whether weaknesses in the temple's cash-handling and monitoring mechanisms allowed the alleged irregularities to continue undetected.



EDITORIAL

PEACE
THROUGH
PRUDENCE

The announcement of a peace agreement between the United States and Iran after 107 days of conflict marks a significant moment not only for West Asia but also for the global economy and international diplomacy. The war had triggered deep anxieties across financial markets, disrupted energy flows and revived fears of a wider regional conflagration. If the agreement holds and translates into a durable political settlement, it could become one of the most consequential diplomatic breakthroughs of recent years. Yet caution remains essential. Peace agreements are judged not by the headlines they generate but by the stability they create.

The conflict demonstrated once again how vulnerable the world remains to developments in the Gulf. The Strait of Hormuz, through which roughly one-fifth of the world's oil supplies pass, emerged as the central pressure point. Any disruption in this narrow maritime corridor immediately reverberates across global energy markets, raising fuel costs, increasing inflationary pressures and threatening economic growth. For countries such as India, which depend heavily on imported energy, the stakes are particularly high. Rising crude prices affect everything from transport and manufacturing to food inflation and household budgets. The prospect of the reopening of Hormuz and the lifting of naval restrictions therefore offers immediate relief to governments, businesses and consumers worldwide. Markets thrive on predictability, and the agreement has already injected a measure of confidence into an uncertain global economic environment.

At the political level, the development highlights the enduring relevance of diplomacy even after prolonged military confrontation. Modern conflicts often begin with the assumption that military superiority can impose political outcomes. History repeatedly proves otherwise. Wars may alter tactical realities, but lasting peace requires negotiation, compromise and mutual recognition of interests. The reported framework of reciprocal commitments, verification mechanisms and phased implementation reflects this reality. Significantly, both Washington and Tehran appear to recognise that neither side can afford an endless cycle of escalation. For the United States, prolonged military engagement in West Asia carries enormous strategic and financial costs. For Iran, continued conflict threatens economic recovery, domestic stability and international engagement. Diplomacy, therefore, has emerged not as a sign of weakness but as a recognition of strategic necessity.

Another notable aspect of the agreement is the role played by regional and middle-power mediators. Pakistan, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and Türkiye reportedly facilitated negotiations and maintained communication channels when direct engagement was difficult. This reflects an evolving international order in which diplomatic influence is no longer monopolised by major powers alone. Regional actors increasingly possess the leverage, credibility and geographic proximity needed to broker solutions to regional crises. Their involvement also underscores the growing preference for dialogue-based conflict resolution over bloc politics and zero-sum geopolitical competition. In a fragmented world, effective mediation has become an indispensable diplomatic asset.

Yet optimism must be tempered by realism. Several unresolved issues remain. Iranian officials have indicated that implementation will be conditional and reciprocal, particularly regarding sanctions relief and future negotiations over the nuclear programme. A 60-day negotiating window on sanctions and nuclear issues suggests that the most difficult conversations may still lie ahead. Decades of mistrust cannot be erased through a single agreement. Verification mechanisms will need to be robust and transparent. Any perceived violation by either side could rapidly unravel the fragile consensus. The history of US-Iran relations is littered with agreements that generated hope before collapsing under the weight of political disagreements and changing strategic calculations.

Equally concerning is the broader regional security environment. Statements from Israeli leaders indicating continued military vigilance and warnings of retaliation reveal that regional tensions have not disappeared. The conflict's spillover into Lebanon and the involvement of multiple actors demonstrate how interconnected West Asian security dynamics have become. A peace accord between Washington and Tehran, while important, cannot by itself resolve every fault line in the region. Sustainable stability will require parallel efforts to address proxy conflicts, security concerns and political grievances that have fuelled instability for decades.

For India, the agreement carries both economic and strategic significance. New Delhi has consistently advocated dialogue, respect for sovereignty and peaceful dispute resolution. Stability in West Asia is vital for India's energy security, trade routes and the welfare of millions of Indian expatriates living and working across the region. Reduced tensions can help secure energy supplies, moderate inflationary pressures and create a more predictable environment for economic growth. At a time when the global economy is already grappling with geopolitical uncertainty, climate disruptions and slowing growth, any reduction in conflict-related risks is welcome.

Ultimately, the significance of this agreement lies not merely in ending a war but in reaffirming a fundamental lesson of international relations: diplomacy remains humanity's most effective instrument for preventing end-less conflict. Military action may alter the battlefield, but only negotiation can build a stable peace. The coming weeks and months will determine whether the United States and Iran can transform a fragile understanding into a durable framework for coexistence. The world should welcome the breakthrough while recognising that the hardest work begins after the signatures are placed on paper. Peace is not an event. It is a process that demands patience, trust and sustained political courage.

EMERGING
CONTEST



G PALANITHURAI

THE WRITER IS A FORMER PROFESSOR AND RAJIV GANDHI CHAIR FOR PANCHAYATI RAJ STUDIES, GANDHIGRAM RURAL INSTITUTE

Whether Tamil Nadu's future political contest is between Vijay and Annamalai remains to be seen, but a new political binary may already be taking shape

GROWTH
BLUEPRINT



JOHN FELIX RAJ & SOVIK MUKHERJEE

JOHN FELIX RAJ IS THE VICE CHANCELLOR, AND SOVIK MUKHERJEE IS AN ASSISTANT PROFESSOR OF ECONOMICS, BOTH AT ST. XAVIER'S UNIVERSITY, KOLKATA

Blockchain, fintech and digital public infrastructure are emerging as critical pillars supporting India's ambition to become 'Viksit Bharat'

Tamil Nadu's New Binary?

The former B7P state chief's decision to launch a political movement signals an attempt to occupy the emerging political space beyond the traditional DMK-AIADMK divide and challenge the rise of Vijay's TVK

Annamalai, a former IPS officer and former State President of the BJP, has started a political movement that, as he has stated, will later become a political party. What made him take such a decision at this juncture is a puzzle for many, not only in Tamil Nadu but also across India. Tamil Nadu politics has moved beyond the earlier binary of the DMK and the AIADMK, as they could not resist the emergence of new forces in the state's political landscape. They were unexpectedly challenged by the TVK under the leadership of Joseph Vijay, the actor-turned-politician, within a short span of time. It was widely believed that Joseph Vijay was merely using his fan base for political purposes through his cinematic influence and that he might not attract the attention of all sections of Tamil society. In reality, however, Joseph Vijay was serious about his mission of dismantling the "empire of corruption." M.G.R. had done something similar by questioning members of the ruling party about their ill-gotten wealth acquired through the misuse of power. Ending corruption is as difficult as ending caste in India. In fact, this transformative process began long ago in Tamil Nadu. It was initiated during the Jallikattu agitation led by the youth and was subsequently taken up by Annamalai when he was the BJP president in Tamil Nadu. Annamalai launched a major campaign against the corruption allegedly perpetrated by both the DMK and the AIADMK.

It was somewhat like Julian Assange's WikiLeaks. Annamalai called it the "DMK Files." These were released one after another and brought to light, in dramatic fashion, the alleged corrupt practices in the governance and



The rise of Vijay and the departure of Annamalai from BJP may redefine Tamil Nadu's future political contest

administration of both Dravidian parties—the DMK and the AIADMK. Supporting this campaign, Union ministers, including the Prime Minister and the Home Minister, repeatedly attacked the alleged corruption of both parties whenever they visited Tamil Nadu. As a result, a large number of young people began following Annamalai because he had taken up the issue with seriousness and persistence. In the parliamentary election, the BJP, based on Annamalai's advice, decided that it did not need to align with the AIADMK. Ultimately, the BJP secured more than 11 per cent of the vote share, which was remarkable, though it failed to win any seats.

As a result, Annamalai was replaced by a softer leader in the BJP, one who had migrated from the AIADMK, and was appointed state president. This enabled the BJP's state unit to join hands with the AIADMK ahead of the Assembly election. While replacing him, the Home Minister stated that Annamalai's role in the party remained important and that he would be given a suitable

position in Delhi. It is often argued that national political parties, including both the Indian National Congress and the Bharatiya Janata Party, do not adequately respect regional leaders or fully recognise their hard work. Barring the Left parties, many national political parties are often described as feudal in nature and character. That is why those skilled in networking, brokerage, and organisational manoeuvring often secure positions, while grassroots workers are left disappointed. Why do people prefer regional political parties? One reason is that they can reach out to their leaders more easily. Annamalai has his own vision and mission, and these may not fit comfortably within the framework of the BJP. Therefore, instead of wasting his time, he chose to move out of the party and start his own political venture.

It is a fact that Joseph Vijay is likely to remain an influential force in politics for the next two decades, and the question is: who will emerge as his principal challenger? It is unlikely to be the

AIADMK, which is currently in disarray. Similarly, the DMK has weakened due to internal challenges and the absence of a towering leader like Karunanidhi. Annamalai appears to view this as a significant political vacuum. The Dravidian model, in many ways, has been appropriated by Joseph Vijay. He, too, speaks about Periyar E.V. Ramasamy and K. Kamaraj, both of whom are regarded as foundational pillars of the Dravidian model in theory.

The failure of the Dravidian parties in the 2026 election, however, would not necessarily signify the failure of the Dravidian model itself. Joseph Vijay appears to be offering that model without the baggage of corruption. People have not opposed the Dravidian model; rather, they have opposed the large-scale corruption associated with governance and administration under the Dravidian parties. Since Joseph Vijay continues many of the welfare schemes introduced by both the DMK and the AIADMK, people appear satisfied, though the traditional Dravidian parties are not. Yet, they continue to claim credit for those schemes. To an extent, that claim is valid. At this juncture, Annamalai seems to have sensed an ideological and leadership vacuum that he believes he can fill, drawing upon his extensive experience of working with people. He is young, energetic, vibrant, persuasive, and currently focused on grassroots politics and development. He has built a substantial youth following and therefore sees himself as part of the emerging political binary. Whether the future political contest in Tamil Nadu will indeed be between Vijay and Annamalai remains to be seen. For now, however, that appears to be the emerging binary in the state's political landscape.

Views expressed are personal

The Fintech Imperative

From UPI to the Digital Rupee, emerging financial technologies are building the foundations of India's next development revolution

As India marches toward its centenary of independence in 2047, the vision of "Viksit Bharat" transitions from an ambitious blueprint into an actionable economic imperative. Achieving this milestone requires sustained, high-octane growth driven by structural transformations. Among the most critical pillars of this progress is a technology-infused financial revolution. Over the last decade, India has repeatedly demonstrated how digital innovation can redefine public infrastructure, democratise economic participation, and bridge longstanding socioeconomic divides.

From the omnipresent Unified Payments Interface (UPI) to digital public infrastructure (DPI), India's financial ecosystem is undergoing a historic paradigm shift. Today, this narrative is expanding. The national conversation around the future of finance increasingly intersects with decentralised finance (DeFi), advanced fintech architecture, and sovereign digital assets. While these disruptive technologies are often viewed cautiously amid global regulatory uncertainty, they hold immense potential to build a highly transparent, efficient, and inclusive economic engine. If harnessed through robust governance, they could serve as definitive catalysts for India's journey toward global digital leadership by 2047.

The Velocity of India's Fintech Revolution

India has firmly established itself as one of the world's fastest-growing fintech ecosystems. According to market data from Invest India, the nation's fintech sector is projected to scale remarkably, targeting nearly USD 1.5 trillion in assets under management and economic revenues by 2030. Currently hosting more than 10,000 fintech startups, India ranks as the third-largest fintech hub globally, trailing only the United States and the United Kingdom.

The centrepiece of this success is the country's unparalleled digital payments infrastructure. The UPI ecosystem, orchestrated by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), reached a historic milestone by processing over 17 billion transactions in a single month in early 2026. This metric underscores how deeply digital commerce has integrated into daily life. From Tier-1 metropolitan retail centers to micro-entrepreneurs and street vendors in remote villages, QR code-based payments have democratized commerce, accelerating India's transition into a cash-light economy.

This transaction velocity has fundamentally rewritten the rules of economic inclusion. Under the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana, more than 55 crore bank accounts have been operationalised, seamlessly integrated with biometric identity verification and mobile banking services. This architecture—the celebrated Jan Dhan-Aadhaar-Mobile (JAM) Trinity—has formed an unshakeable foundation



A robust digital financial ecosystem could become India's most powerful catalyst for inclusive growth, innovation and global economic leadership

for public service delivery, minimising leakages and establishing an international benchmark for inclusive digital growth. Deconstructing Decentralised Finance (DeFi) and Blockchain

As the baseline digital layer matures, attention is pivoting toward the next frontier: Decentralised Finance (DeFi). Operating on blockchain protocols, DeFi eliminates traditional financial intermediaries through automated smart contracts. Globally, this ecosystem has expanded significantly, with the Total Value Locked (TVL) in DeFi protocols crossing USD 90 billion during cyclical peaks, signalling deep institutional and retail interest in alternative financial architectures.

The structural value proposition of DeFi lies in its absolute transparency, cryptographic security, and operational efficiency. For a developing economy like India, where formal credit penetration remains uneven, decentralised paradigms offer compelling alternatives. Small and Medium Enterprises (SMEs), casual labourers, freelancers, and agrarian entrepreneurs frequently encounter barriers when seeking institutional credit due to a lack of conventional collateral or formal credit scoring. Blockchain-based peer-to-peer lending platforms and decentralised identity verification can bypass these structural bottlenecks, matching underbanked segments with liquid capital directly and securely.

Furthermore, blockchain integration can optimise supply chain logistics, secure public registries, and streamline cross-border trade. This is particularly vital for international remittances. With the World Bank estimating that India received nearly USD 125 billion in remittances in 2025, deploying low-cost, near-instantaneous blockchain payment corridors could save billions in legacy banking fees, redirecting capital directly into rural and semi-urban households.

Cryptocurrency and the Sovereign Digital Frontier

Any forward-looking assessment of digital finance must address the complex dynamics of virtual digital assets (VDAs). Cryptocurrencies like Bitcoin

and Ethereum have challenged traditional assumptions regarding monetary sovereignty and asset allocation. India boasts one of the largest retail digital asset user bases globally, driven largely by tech-savvy urban populations and a growing cohort of young investors.

Faced with this rapid adoption, Indian policymakers have championed a pragmatic approach that balances consumer safety with technological progression. Regulatory frameworks—including a 30% tax on digital asset gains and a 1% Tax Deducted at Source (TDS) on transactions—reflect a deliberate shift away from outright prohibition toward structured regularisation and fiscal oversight. This framework aims to mitigate risks associated with extreme market volatility, illicit capital flights, and consumer vulnerability.

Concurrently, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has proactively countered decentralised volatility by pioneering its own sovereign digital asset: the Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC), or Digital Rupee. By early 2026, the RBI's wholesale and retail CBDC pilots scaled across multiple commercial banking networks, successfully processing millions of transactions. The Digital Rupee offers the cryptographic advantages of blockchain—such as programmable distribution and instant settlement finality—while maintaining the absolute stability and backing of a sovereign central bank. This duality encapsulates India's broader policy ethos: fostering native innovation while maintaining strict macroeconomic stability.

Driving Inclusion and Empowering the Gig Economy

The overarching metric of success for Viksit Bharat remains equitable human development. Traditional financial architectures historically marginalised vulnerable demographics—including rural women, migratory workforces, and low-income segments—due to rigid documentation requirements or geographical constraints. Fintech applications have systematically dismantled these barriers through micro-investments, fractional

insurance products, and algorithm-driven alternative credit scoring.

This empowerment is vividly apparent within India's exploding gig economy. Estimates by NITI Aayog suggest that India's gig workforce is on track to exceed 2.35 crore workers by 2030. This decentralised labour force—comprising app-based delivery partners, freelance consultants, and content creators—relies entirely on instantaneous digital wallets, automated payroll mechanisms, and micro-credit lines to sustain their livelihoods.

Mitigating Systemic Risks and the Digital Divide

However, the trajectory toward a fully digitised economy is not without systemic vulnerabilities. Cryptographic markets are inherently volatile, exposing retail participants to steep financial risks. Concurrently, global DeFi protocols remain susceptible to smart-contract exploits, sophisticated phishing networks, and cyber-attacks that operate outside traditional institutional recovery frameworks.

Domestically, the structural challenge of the digital divide persists. True financial democratisation depends heavily on universal smartphone access, robust rural internet penetration, and widespread digital literacy. While bodies like the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) note surging rural connectivity, a measurable urban-rural cleavage remains. If left unaddressed, the dividends of the Web3 and fintech revolutions risk concentrating wealth within affluent urban clusters.

Finally, ecological sustainability must remain central to technological deployment. Transitioning away from energy-intensive consensus mechanisms (like Proof-of-Work) toward sustainable protocols is imperative to ensure that technological progress aligns with India's climate commitments.

Crafting the Hybrid Financial Horizon

The realisation of Viksit Bharat 2047 hinges on building a nation that is technologically advanced, structurally equitable, and globally competitive. Emerging financial technologies are not mere administrative upgrades; they are foundational instruments of economic sovereignty.

The optimal path forward does not lie in replacing legacy banking institutions, but in fostering a highly collaborative, hybrid financial ecosystem. By synthesising the agility of decentralised innovation with the stability of public oversight, India can continue to scale its digital public infrastructure safely. Ultimately, balancing bold financial innovation with proactive, consumer-centric regulation will ensure that India's digital economy becomes an engine of shared prosperity, powering the nation toward its developed future.

Views expressed are personal

'Israel won't withdraw from land seized in Lebanon, Syria, Gaza'

Pictures were posted by the centre on its Facebook page, showing their medics wearing white hazmat suits carrying bodies in black and white plastic bags and other pictures taken during the burials.

TRADE DEFICIT WIDENS TO \$28.21 BILLION

Exports jump to six-month high of 18% to \$45.2 billion in May

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India's exports climbed to a six-month high of 18 per cent to \$45.2 billion in May, while trade deficit widened to \$28.21 billion, driven by increased imports of petroleum products amid higher crude oil prices.

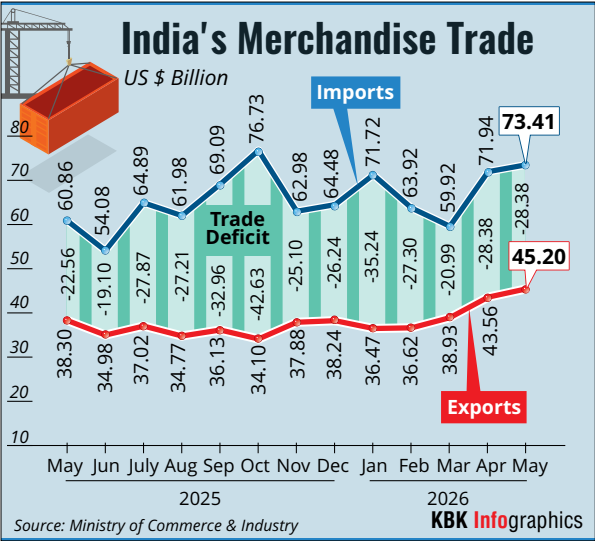
However, the trade deficit narrowed marginally on a month-on-month basis compared to \$28.38 billion recorded in April. The trade gap stood at \$22.56 billion in May last year.

Imports grew 10 per cent year-on-year to a three-month high of \$73.41 billion in May, widening the trade deficit from a year ago.

Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said that despite global geopolitical uncertainties, the country's exports are registering good growth.

The May export numbers are "one of the highest", he said, adding that going by the trend, this year will be good for exports.

The key drivers of exports include electronic goods (up 11.62 per cent to \$5.09 billion), petroleum products (up 54.89 per cent to \$8.42 billion), engineering items (24.48 per cent to \$12.31 billion) and pharmaceuticals (6.63 per cent to \$2.62 billion).



However, exports of tea, tobacco, spices, cashew, marine products, leather and textiles recorded negative growth in May.

During April-May 2026-27, exports rose 16.09 per cent to \$88.91 billion, while imports jumped 15.14 per cent to \$145.35 billion. The trade deficit stood at \$56.44 billion during the period.

Oil imports in May rose 53.8 per cent to \$22.67 billion due to high prices, which hovered at around \$100 per barrel in that month. These imports rose 16.5 per cent to \$41.3 billion during April-May 2026-27. Similarly, electronic

imports were up 35.5 per cent to \$21.31 billion in May.

Agrawal said the country's exports to West Asia in May this year have almost reached the level of last May despite disruptions in that region.

India's exports to West Asia in May was marginally down at \$5.30 billion against \$5.38 billion in May 2025. India has used three ports (Dugm, Sohar and Salalah) of Oman to push the shipments in that region.

The data comes as US President Donald Trump announced that the US and Iran have finalised a deal to end their 107-day war, which triggered a global energy crisis.

Highlights

» During April-May 2026-27, exports rose 16.09 per cent to \$88.91 billion, while imports rose 15.14 per cent to \$145.35 billion

» The trade deficit stood at \$56.44 billion during the period

» Oil imports rose 53.8% to \$22.67 bn in May due to high prices, at around \$100/barrel. These imports rose 16.5% to \$41.3 billion during April-May FY27

The peace agreement is scheduled to be signed on June 19 in Switzerland. The US-Iran conflict has severely impacted the movement of ships carrying cargoes in international waters, particularly through the Strait of Hormuz.

On the impact of the peace deal, the secretary said, "We hope it's a sustained deal which brings peace in the region...The deal has been in offing for more than a month, and now that it has come, it should be a deal which can be sustained."

The opening of the Strait of Hormuz and peace in the region would be positive for India's trade, he said.

Meanwhile, as per government estimates, services exports stood at \$36.76 billion in May, and imports were \$19.06 billion.

Commenting on the data, Federation of Indian Export Organisations (FIEO) President S C Ralhan said the recent diplomatic breakthrough in West Asia, with regard to the emerging peace framework involving the US, Iran and the broader regional stakeholders, is a positive development for global trade, shipping and supply chains.

"The reported reopening of the Strait of Hormuz and the de-escalation of geopolitical tensions are expected to improve the movement of goods, stabilise freight and insurance costs, and enhance predictability in international trade flows, but also for our Indian exporters, thereby further providing a boost to our exports in the coming months as GCC is one of our key markets," he said.

The depreciating Indian rupee is also helping the country's exports. It has depreciated nearly 5 per cent so far this year. The rupee closed Monday's session 60 paise higher at 94.58 against the US dollar as crude oil prices dropped below \$83 per barrel following the announcement of the West Asia peace deal.

Adani & Jabil partner for AI, data centre hardware making venture

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Adani Group and US-based electronics manufacturer Jabil Inc on Monday announced plans to form a strategic alliance to build a large-scale artificial intelligence (AI) and data centre infrastructure manufacturing platform in India, targeting both domestic demand and global exports.

The proposed partnership aims to manufacture high-density AI racks, servers, storage systems, networking equipment and supporting power and cooling infrastructure, as India seeks to position itself as a global hub for AI hardware production.

In a statement, Adani Enterprises and Jabil said the platform would target multi-gigawatt AI rack manufacturing capacity and cater to hyperscale cloud providers, colocation operators and enterprise data centres worldwide.

The alliance combines Jabil's engineering and manufacturing expertise with Adani Group's infrastructure, renewable energy and data centre businesses to address what the companies described as rapidly growing demand for AI-ready data centre infrastructure, it said.

The partners said they are working on definitive agreements and operational frameworks for the venture, which they estimate could tap into a global AI infrastructure market opportunity exceeding \$3 trillion over the next seven years.

Beyond AI computing racks, the manufacturing platform will



Adani Enterprises & Jabil said platform would target multi-gigawatt AI rack manufacturing capacity

also produce key data centre components including power distribution units, coolant distribution units, transformers, switchgear, busbars and thermal management systems, providing an integrated hardware ecosystem for data centre developers.

The announcement comes as India ramps up investments in digital infrastructure, with industry estimates projecting domestic data centre capacity to reach 5-8 gigawatts by 2030, driven by AI adoption, cloud expansion and data localisation requirements.

The proposed venture aligns with Adani Group's previously announced \$100 billion investment commitment to develop 5 GW of green energy-powered, AI-ready data centres by 2035.

Jabil, which reported fiscal 2025 revenue of \$29.8 billion, has expanded its AI infrastructure capabilities through invest-

ments and acquisitions in power management and thermal solutions businesses.

"The world is entering an Intelligence Revolution more profound than any previous Industrial Revolution. Nations that master the symmetry between energy and compute will shape the next decade. India is uniquely positioned to lead.

"Our alliance with Jabil represents a decisive step in building India's complete AI infrastructure stack - from green power generation to world-class hardware manufacturing. Together, we will ensure India is not merely a consumer in the AI age, but a creator, builder, and exporter of intelligence," Gautam Adani, chairman of Adani Group, said.

"This strategic collaboration with Adani Group is another step forward in our efforts to create long-term value for customers throughout the AI ecosystem by offering scalable solutions across the product lifecycle. "By combining Jabil's more than sixty years of engineering expertise and advanced manufacturing capabilities with Adani's formidable infrastructure and energy platform, we can expect to execute down to the rack level for hyperscalers and enterprises here in India and across the globe. As India becomes one of the world's fastest-growing AI markets, the country's skilled workforce and supportive business environment make it an attractive destination for this collaboration," Jabil Chief Executive Mike Dastoor said.

India's exports to US remain flat, imports rise 54.43% in May

NEW DELHI: India's exports to the US remained flat at \$8.81 billion in May, while imports rose 54.43 per cent year-on-year to \$5.87 billion, according to the government data. In May 2025, exports to the US stood at \$8.82 billion, while imports were reported at \$3.8 billion.

During April-May FY27, India's merchandise exports rose marginally by 0.5 per cent to \$17.3 billion, while imports increased 19.43 per cent to \$11.14 billion.

India's exports to China rose 24.8 per cent in May to \$2 billion, while imports from rose 23.4 per cent to \$12.8 billion. The trade deficit stood at \$10.8 billion. During April-May FY27, India's merchandise exports to China rose 25.85 per cent to \$3.8 billion, while imports rose 22.15 per cent to \$24.7 billion.

India has also recorded positive exports growth to Singapore, the UK, Tanzania, Germany, South Africa, Australia, Sri Lanka, Italy & Vietnam during the reporting period.

However, exports to the Netherlands, Bangladesh and Nepal registered negative growth in May. On the other hand, imports from Russia, Korea, Singapore, Japan, Germany, Thailand, Malaysia & Brazil increased.

Imports from Brazil rose 358.83 to \$1.35 billion in May, while imports from Peru grew 208.94 per cent to \$781.52.

Gold imports up 34% to \$3.41 bn in May, silver shipments fall over 86%

NEW DELHI: India's gold imports rose by 34 per cent year-on-year to \$3.41 billion in May, driven by high prices of the precious metal, while silver imports dipped 86.65 per cent during the month, according to the Commerce Ministry data.

The government increased import duty on precious metals from 6 per cent to 15 per cent effective May 13. According to the data, silver imports dipped to \$75.57 million during the month under review from \$566.22 million in May 2025.

The rise in gold imports in May pushed the country's trade deficit to \$28.21 billion. The price of the yellow metal is hovering near Rs 1,60,000 per 10 grams in the national capital. Silver was priced at around Rs 2.60 lakh per Kg.

Switzerland is the largest



source of gold imports, with about 40 per cent share, followed by the UAE (over 16 per cent) and South Africa (about 10 per cent). In May, total gold imports from Switzerland dipped 57.73 per cent and by 20.34 per cent during the first two months of FY27.

The precious metal accounts for over 5 per cent of the country's total imports.

During April-May FY27, gold imports rose 60.14 per cent to \$9.04 billion, while silver imports declined about 33

per cent to \$486.58 million.

In FY26, gold imports rose by 24 per cent to hit an all-time high of \$71.98 billion. In volume terms, however, the imports dipped 4.76 per cent to 721.03 tonnes. India is the world's second-biggest gold consumer after China. The imports mainly meet the demand of the jewellery industry. The imports have implications for India's current account deficit (CAD).

India reported a current account surplus of \$7.1 billion, or 0.7 per cent of GDP, in Q4 FY26, according to the RBI data. The surplus stood at \$13.7 billion, or 1.4 per cent of GDP, in Q4 FY25. However, for the entire fiscal, the current account deficit stood at \$25.2 billion, or 0.6 per cent of GDP, against \$22.9 billion, or 0.6 per cent of GDP, during FY25.

Anil Agarwal hints at relisting of parent Vedanta Resources, each biz can hit \$100 billion revenue

MUMBAI: Vedanta Chairman Anil Agarwal on Monday hinted at a possible overseas relisting of parent Vedanta Resources and outlined an ambitious growth strategy, saying each of the group's business verticals has the potential to become a \$100 billion opportunity over time.

Speaking after the stock market debut of Vedanta's four demerged entities — Vedanta Aluminium Metal, Vedanta Power, Vedanta Oil and Gas, and Vedanta Iron and Steel — Agarwal said, "We have delisted our company in London, which was a FTSE 100 company. It's not on the card, but there is a potential that we can relist that company, maybe in America,



Vedanta Chairman Anil Agarwal

maybe somewhere else, and create phenomenal value."

Agarwal said the group currently generates annual revenue of about \$23-24 billion and aims to scale it up to \$50 billion through expansion across metals, mining, energy and critical minerals.

Vedanta's demerger,

approved by the National Company Law Tribunal in December last year, follows a 1:1 share allotment scheme under which shareholders receive one share of each demerged company for every share held in Vedanta Ltd.

The company has said the restructuring will simplify its corporate structure and provide investors with direct exposure to sector-focused businesses.

Highlighting growth plans, Agarwal said Vedanta intends to significantly increase aluminium production, citing India's low per-capita aluminium consumption of 3 kg compared with the global average of 30-40 kg.

In oil and gas, he said the company has mapped resources

capable of raising production to 5,00,000 barrels in three years through deeper exploration.

Vedanta is also targeting steel production of 15 million tonnes, supported by captive iron ore and coking coal resources. "We have all the infrastructure," Agarwal said.

He further revealed a long-term nuclear energy strategy, stating that 20-25 per cent of the company's future power generation capacity could eventually come from atomic energy.

The group's four newly demerged companies made their market debut on Monday, marking a major milestone in Vedanta's restructuring and expansion plans.

NEW DELHI: The government on Monday hiked windfall gains tax on exports of diesel and aviation turbine fuel (ATF), while retaining the levy on petrol for the fortnight beginning June 16.

The rate of special additional excise duty (SAED) on export of diesel will be Rs 14/litre, up from Rs 13.5/litre at present. SAED on export of ATF will be Rs 12.5/litre, up from Rs 9.5/litre.

There is no change in the rate of duty on exports of petrol and it continues to be at Rs 1.5 per litre.

The Finance Ministry in a notification said the duty hikes will be effective from June 16.

Also, there is no change in the existing duty rates on petrol



and diesel cleared for domestic consumption.

Amid escalating tensions in West Asia caused by the US-Israel attack on Iran, followed by sweeping retaliation, the government had on March 26 imposed an export duty on diesel and ATF and revised the rate every fortnight. On May 16, it levied export duty on petrol.

The windfall tax was levied to increase domestic availabil-

There is no change in the rate of duty on exports of petrol and it continues to be at Rs 1.5/litre

ity of the fuel amid the war in West Asia.

The move is aimed at not allowing exporters to take undue advantage due to price differences as globally crude oil prices had risen since the beginning of the war.

The windfall tax is to ensure domestic availability of petroleum products by disincentivising exports in the backdrop of the West Asia crisis.

Unemployment rate declines marginally to 5.5% in May: Labour Force Survey

According to the PLFS for May, 2026, the overall unemployment rate (UR) for persons aged 15 years and above was 5.2 per cent in April this year

NEW DELHI: Overall unemployment rate for persons aged 15 years and above has dipped marginally to 5.5 per cent in May compared to 5.6 per cent a year ago, as shown by the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) released by the National Statistics Office on Monday.

According to the PLFS for May, 2026, the overall unemployment rate (UR) for persons aged 15 years and above was 5.2 per cent in April this year.

The PLFS conducted by NSO, Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, is the primary source of data on activity participation

and employment and unemployment conditions of the population. The PLFS survey methodology has been modified from January, 2025 to provide monthly and quarterly estimates of labour force indicators for the country.

Monthly results of PLFS present estimates of key labour market indicators viz. Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR), Worker Population Ratio (WPR) and Unemployment Rate (UR) at the all-India level following the Current Weekly Status (CWS) approach.

The Monthly Bulletins for April, 2025 to April, 2026 have

already been released. The present Monthly Bulletin for May, 2026 is the fourteenth in the series. According to the statement, in May 2026, the rural UR increased marginally to 5.1 per cent from 4.6 per cent in April, 2026, while the urban UR eased to 6.4 per cent from 6.6 per cent during the same period.

The overall UR was estimated at 5.5 per cent in May, 2026. Compared with May, 2025, the urban UR declined from 6.9 per cent to 6.4 per cent, marking a reduction of 0.5 percentage points in May, 2026, it stated. The overall UR

CLOSER LOOK

» According to the statement, in May 2026, the rural UR increased marginally to 5.1% from 4.6% in April, 2026

» While the urban UR in May 2026 eased to 6.4 per cent from 6.6 per cent during April, 2026

» Against May, 2025, urban UR fell from 6.9% to 6.4%, marking a fall of 0.5 percentage points in May, 2026

remained stable, while the rural UR maintained the same level of 5.1 per cent over the same period, it stated.

Urban UR recorded its lowest level since May, 2025, it also stated. At the all-India level, the monthly estimates are based on

information collected from a total number of 3,73,887 persons surveyed.

The Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR) for persons aged 15 years and above was reported as 54.4 per cent in May, 2026, compared to 55.0

per cent in April, 2026, it stated.

In rural and urban areas, LFPR was recorded at 56.6 per cent and 49.8 per cent, respectively. The year-on-year comparison shows that the overall LFPR in May, 2026 declined by 0.4 percentage points.

Rural and urban LFPR also registered a decline of 0.3 and 0.6 percentage points, respectively, over the same period, it stated. Female Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR) for age 15 years and above stood at 32.8 per cent in May, 2026.

In rural areas, female LFPR was recorded at 36.7 per cent, whereas it remained almost at

the same level at 24.8 per cent in urban areas compared to the previous month.

Compared to May, 2025, the overall female LFPR declined marginally by 0.4 percentage points, from 33.2 per cent to 32.8 per cent in May, 2026. Rural female LFPR remained broadly unchanged, whereas LFPR for urban female recorded a decline of 0.5 percentage points over the year.

The Worker Population Ratio (WPR) for persons aged 15 years and above recorded a marginal decline of 0.3 percentage points in both rural and urban sectors between

May, 2025 and May, 2026, it stated.

The overall WPR was estimated at 51.4 per cent in May, 2026, compared to 52.2 per cent in April, 2026 and 51.7 per cent in May, 2025.

In rural areas, WPR stood at 53.8 per cent in May, 2026, compared to 54.9 per cent in April, 2026. WPR in urban areas was estimated at 46.6 per cent in May, 2026 against 46.8 per cent in April, 2026.

It explained that the moderation in LFPR and WPR with an increase in UR indicates a softening of labour market conditions during the period.

More measures likely to attract foreign capital, says Sitharaman

There is a need to be prepared for exigencies arising from evolving global situation, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Monday said the measures announced by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and government to boost foreign fund inflows are the “first step” to bring back foreign capital and indicated that more steps could be in the offing.

Sitharaman also said that there is a need to be prepared for exigencies arising out of the evolving global situation as the Indian economy is facing “severe strain” from import of key raw materials, as well crude oil and fertilisers.

Speaking at the Mindmine Summit 2026, Sitharaman said an analysis by the RBI and the government has shown that the bond market can be a “very good magnet” to absorb foreign capital.

Accordingly, to reduce compliance burden for foreign investors in Government Securities (G-Secs), the government on June 5 expanded the list of specified securities under the Fully Accessible Route (FAR) to also include new issuances in G-Secs.

Besides, income tax exemption was given to income from



Union Finance & Corporate Affairs Minister Nirmala Sitharaman speaks during the Mindmine Summit 2026, in New Delhi on Monday

interest and capital gains made by FPIs from investments in G-Secs.

Sitharaman said these measures are the “first step” towards drawing foreign capital back. “Although at the moment it’s confined to the bond market, certainly that’s not the end of the story. There will be more. We recognise, we need more foreign capital to come in,” Sitharaman said.

The RBI on June 5 had allowed banks to access the RBI’s swap facility for Foreign Currency Non-Resident

(Bank) (FCNR(B), deposits with maturities ranging from 3-5 years till September 30.

The facility would allow banks to swap US dollar deposits with the RBI, and manage currency risks.

Further, to shore up foreign capital inflows, RBI has brought in a forex swap facility to encourage PSUs to raise external commercial borrowings (ECBs) until September 30.

Sitharaman said under the framework announced by the RBI, currency hedging will be

Highlights

» ‘Indian economy is facing ‘severe strain’ from import of key raw materials, as well crude oil and fertilisers’

» ‘An analysis by the RBI & govt has shown that the bond market can be a ‘very good magnet’ to absorb foreign capital’

» ‘Although at the moment it’s confined to the bond market, certainly that’s not the end of the story,’ Sitharaman said

at the expense of the central bank.

“And as a result, the banks can now go unfettered, to raise their own funds. So we have taken a very calibrated approach to make sure that the markets do see the required investments,” Sitharaman said.

Government sources had earlier said that more measures to increase FDI flows into the economy are in the offing, which will help bolster forex reserves and stabilise rupee value.

India’s foreign exchange

reserves declined by \$711 million to \$681.610 billion in the week ended June 5.

Government sources had earlier said that in view of rising fertiliser prices globally, the fertiliser ministry has sought a 100 per cent increase in subsidy for the current fiscal. The budget has estimated a fertiliser subsidy of Rs 1.71 lakh crore for the current fiscal.

The closure of the Strait of Hormuz due to the crisis in West Asia will have an impact on the fertiliser import bill. Also, the narrowing of available pool of fertilisers in the global market is making the global tendering process complex.

This is leading to two major challenges in fertiliser import - the first one is securing supplies and the tendering process, while the other is the rate and speed of change in fertiliser prices.

Also, the closure of Hormuz has spiked crude import bills. India imports about 87 per cent of its crude requirement, of which 46 per cent is transiting through or near the Strait of Hormuz.

Also, the country imports 60 per cent of its LPG usage and of that, 90 per cent flows through the Strait.

US-IRAN DEAL BOOST INVESTOR SENTIMENT

Markets climb for 2nd day in row on sharp drop in crude oil prices

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Stock markets rose for the second straight session with benchmark Sensex closing higher by 736 points on Monday, propelled by a rally in global equities and a sharp decline in crude oil prices after the US and Iran finalised a deal to end their 107-day war.

The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 736.38 points, or 0.97 per cent, to settle at 76,264.33. During the day, it zoomed 1,293.12 points, or 1.71 per cent, to 76,821.07.

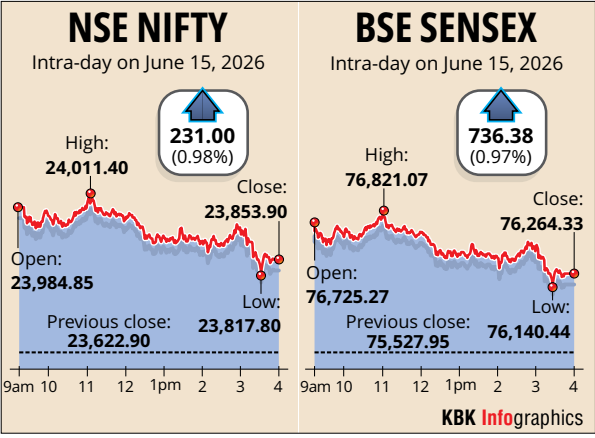
Rising for the second day, the 50-share NSE Nifty surged 231 points, or 0.98 per cent, to end at 23,853.90. During the day, the benchmark rallied 388.5 points, or 1.64 per cent, to 24,011.40.

Sensex had rallied 1,695 points or 2.3 per cent and Nifty soared by 461 points or nearly 2 per cent in the previous session on Friday.

The market capitalisation (mcap) of BSE-listed companies went up by Rs 18,15,339 crore to Rs 4,70,49,119.48 crore in two days.

The US and Iran finalised a deal to end their 107-day war and open the Strait of Hormuz, the narrow waterway used to ferry one-fifth of the global oil supplies, on Friday after an in-person signing of the agreement in Switzerland.

US President Donald Trump made the announcement on Truth Social on Sunday eve-



The mcap of BSE-listed companies went up by Rs 18,15,339 crore to Rs 4,70,49,119.48 crore in two days

ning, easing pressure on the global energy markets, as officials said the peace agreement would be signed on June 19 in Switzerland. Crude oil prices fell to three-month lows in global markets after the announcement of the US-Iran deal.

Global benchmark Brent Crude dropped 5 per cent to trade near \$82.90 per barrel.

Among 30 Sensex firms, Trent was the biggest gainer, rising by 5.35 per cent, InterGlobe Aviation jumped 3.62 per cent, Bajaj Finserv by 3.58 per cent, UltraTech Cement by 3.29 per

cent, Eternal by 3.26 per cent and Maruti by 3.06 per cent.

NTPC fell the most by 1.64 per cent, followed by ICICI Bank, Asian Paints and Hindustan Unilever.

Broader markets advanced as the BSE MidCap Select index jumped 1.66 per cent and Small-Cap Select index climbed 1 per cent.

Sectorally, Realty surged the most by 3.93 per cent, followed by Auto (2.69 per cent), Consumer Discretionary (2.44 per cent), Consumer Durables (2.02 per cent), Industrials (1.73 per cent) and Services (1.66 per cent). Hospitals, Healthcare and Metal were the laggards.

A total of 3,086 stocks advanced, while 1,323 declined and 206 remained unchanged on the BSE.

FII offloaded equities worth Rs 1,082.18 crore on Friday, according to exchange data.

India records \$4.7 billion current account surplus in April: RBI data

MUMBAI: India recorded a current account surplus of \$4.7 billion in April as against a deficit of \$4.8 billion in the year-ago month, on the back of higher services exports and net transfer receipts, according to Reserve Bank data released on Monday.

The imports bill was at \$72.5 billion, up from \$65.8 billion, while exports stood at \$44.6 billion compared to \$38.7 billion, according to preliminary data on India’s Balance of Payments (BoP).

The merchandise trade deficit stood at \$27.9 billion in April 2026, marginally higher than \$27.1 billion in April 2025.

Net services receipts increased to \$18.6 billion during April from \$15.9 billion in April 2025. Services exports stood at \$37 billion, while



imports were \$18.4 billion.

Net transfers increased to \$16 billion in April 2026 from \$9.4 billion a year earlier, said the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) data.

On the capital account, India recorded a net outflow of \$11.3 billion in April 2026 as against a net inflow of \$5.3 billion in the corresponding month last year.

Net foreign direct investment (FDI) increased to \$7.4

billion in April from \$1.6 billion a year ago.

Foreign portfolio investment (FPI) recorded a net outflow of \$8.7 billion during April 2026, the data said.

The overall Balance of Payments registered a deficit of \$6.6 billion in April 2026, against a surplus of \$0.5 billion in April 2025.

In the January-March quarter of 2025-26, India had posted a current account surplus of \$7.1 billion or 0.7 per cent of GDP as compared to \$13.7 billion or 1.4 per cent of GDP in the year-ago quarter.

Henceforth, India’s BoP data for the reference month will be released by the 15th day or earlier of the second subsequent month, the Reserve Bank of India said.

Govt releases PPI data, to replace WPI in 5 yrs

NEW DELHI: The government on Monday came out with producer price index (PPI) data for both goods and services for the first time to better reflect price movement, paving the way for phasing out wholesale price inflation numbers in the next five years.

This is in line with practices adopted by advanced economies and the recommendations of the IMF, which stressed that there is a growing need for India to transition from the wholesale price index (WPI) to the PPI.

Availability of both output and input PPI would give a better understanding of the price movements of output items vis-a-vis input items being used in an industry.

“It also explains how inflation experienced by producers on input items is passed through the output being produced,” the Commerce and Industry Ministry said, adding that the release

of WPI index would be discontinued after 5 years.

All India Output PPI for all commodities for May 2026 stands at 109.6, whereas it was 108.6 in April 2026.

All-India trial Input PPI for the manufacturing sector in May 2026 stands at 104.9.

The ministry said the input PPI is being published on an experimental basis and would enable the department to examine the data quality and also receive feedback of stakeholders and users.

Along with the May WPI data, the government on Monday released the output and input PPIs for the first time. In line with the WPI inflation, which increased to 9.68 per cent in May from 8.26 per cent in April, the output PPI increased to 9.4 per cent in May from 8.1 per cent in April.

The revised base year for both WPI and PPI data is 2022-

23 and includes 957 items.

The ministry said the revised series of WPI and Output PPI (Goods) cover all representative goods transacted in the economy, whereas Input PPI (Goods) covers all representative goods consumed by the manufacturing industry.

Seven services -- banking, securities transaction, insurance, management of pension funds, railways, air (passenger), and telecom -- have been covered in the first phase of Service PPI, while remaining services will be covered in the next phase, which would use the data collected through price collection survey of sampled establishments, obtained from GSTN, the Commerce and Industry Ministry said.

Manufactured items have the highest 69.93 per cent weight in output PPI (Goods), followed by agriculture, forestry and fishing (22.16 per cent),

electricity (4.49 per cent), and mining and quarrying (3.42 per cent).

In the case of Service PPI, no weights are being assigned, since the seven services are not covering the entire service sector. Accordingly, indices of the seven services would be released without their respective weights.

This compares to WPI weightage of 63.12 per cent for manufactured products, 14.11 per cent for fuel and power, and 22.76 per cent for primary articles.

The shift from WPI to PPI follows the submission of the report of the working group under former NITI Aayog member Ramesh Chand in April. The group was set up on December 30, 2024, with the mandate to revise the base year of the WPI from 2011-12 to 2022-23, and compile the PPI with 2022-23 as the base year.

Rupee jumps 60 paise to 94.58/dollar



MUMBAI: The rupee strengthened 60 paise to settle at 94.58 against the US dollar on Monday as global crude oil prices dropped sharply after US President Donald Trump announced that the US and Iran finalised a deal to end the war.

A surge in the domestic equity markets and a weaker US dollar further drove the local unit, forex traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 94.70 against the US dollar and traded in the range of 94.45-94.77.

Eventually, it settled at 94.58, up 60 paise from its previous close.

The rupee jumped 67 paise to close at 95.18 against the greenback on Friday.

The US and Iran finalised a deal to end their 107-day war and open the Strait of Hormuz, the narrow waterway used to ferry one-fifth of the global oil supplies. The deal is expected to be signed on Friday in Switzerland.

The dollar index, which gauges the greenback’s strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 99.65, down 0.20 per cent.

India’s forex reserves dropped \$711 million to \$681.610 billion during the week ended June 5 due to a sharp decline in foreign currency reserves, the RBI said on Friday.

Jaiprakash Associates to be delisted from exchanges from June 18

NEW DELHI: Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL), which has been acquired by Adani Enterprises through the insolvency process, will get delisted from stock exchanges with effect from June 18.

In a regulatory filing on Monday, JAL informed that it has received final approval from the BSE Ltd and NSE for delisting of its equity shares from both stock exchanges.

Accordingly, the company’s equity shares would stand delisted from the BSE and the NSE with effect from June 18, 2026.

The delisting is as per the resolution plan approved by the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT), Allahabad Bench, Prayagraj.

Last month, the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) rejected a challenge by Anil Agarwal’s Vedanta Ltd to the winning bid by Adani group for bankrupt real estate firm JAL.

The NCLAT held that the Committee of Creditors (CoC) were right in preferring Adani Groups Rs 14,535-crore bid over Vedanta’s resolution plan for JAL.

Kotak MF launches maiden SIF with Infinity Hybrid Long-Short Fund

NEW DELHI: Kotak Mahindra Asset Management Company (‘Kotak Mutual Fund’/‘KMAMC’) on Monday announced the launch of its maiden Specialised Investment Fund (SIF) - the Kotak Infinity Hybrid Long-Short Fund, marking its entry into SEBI’s newly introduced SIF category.

SIFs are a new investment category designed to bridge the gap between traditional mutual funds and more advanced offerings such as PMS and AIFs.

They may offer relatively greater flexibility in portfolio construction, subject to applicable regulatory provisions, and are generally suited for investors who understand the

associated features and risks. The strategy aims to navigate different market conditions through dynamic management of net equity exposure, with a focus on portfolio risk management, including downside risks.

It involves a combination of long-only investments, permitted short exposures and arbitrage opportunities, in line with regulatory limits. However, there is no assurance that the stated objectives will be achieved or that the strategy will deliver consistent or stable outcomes across market cycles. The New Fund Offer (NFO) will open on June 15, 2026, and close on June 29, 2026.

Nilesh Shah, Managing

Director, Kotak Mahindra Asset Management Company Ltd says “Mutual funds have created significant wealth through disciplined long-only investing. SIFs represent a natural evolution, offering greater flexibility through long-short strategies to navigate market cycles more effectively. With experience in managing hybrid strategies, the Infinity Hybrid Long-Short Fund is positioned to provide an additional approach to investing, with a focus on disciplined portfolio construction and risk management. However, there is no assurance that the investment objectives will be achieved or that the strategy will result in favourable outcomes.”

India targets 100 GW wind capacity by 2030, scale it up to 155 GW by 2035: Pralhad Joshi

The new & renewable energy minister also launched WT-MARUT portal, India’s first dedicated digital platform for wind supply chain management

NEW DELHI: India is aiming to achieve 100 GW (giga-watt) of installed wind energy capacity by 2030 from more than 56.1 GW currently and scale it up further to 155 GW by 2035, Union Minister for New and Renewable Energy Pralhad Joshi said on Monday while launching WT-MARUT, the country’s first wind turbine supply chain management portal.

Launched during a Global Wind Day conference organised by the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) in Goa with support from industry bodies including the Indian Wind Turbine Manufacturers

Association (IWTMA), Wind Independent Power Producers Association (WIPPA) and Indian Wind Power Association (IWPA), WT-MARUT is India’s first dedicated digital platform for wind supply chain management.

According to the government, the portal is designed to strengthen domestic manufacturing, enhance supply chain transparency and boost exports. It will provide visibility into component sourcing, support domestic sourcing requirements under the Approved List of Models and Manufacturers (ALMM) framework, enable

supplier discovery and qualification, strengthen collaboration across the supply chain and improve export readiness. The platform also facilitates end-to-end tracking of wind energy components from manufacturing facilities to project sites, ensuring traceability, accountability and compliance across the value chain.

“We are confident the wind energy sector will achieve 100 GW of wind installations by 2030 and 155 GW by 2035. As India enters its next phase of growth, unlocking global opportunities will be critical, and initiatives like WT-

CLOSER LOOK

- » He highlighted country’s record addition of 6.1 GW of wind power capacity in FY26, a 46% year-on-year rise
- » ‘Portal is designed to strengthen domestic manufacturing, enhance supply chain transparency and boost exports’
- » ‘Platform facilitates end-to-end tracking of wind energy components from manufacturing facilities to project sites’

MARUT will strengthen supply chain visibility, boost domestic manufacturing and enhance India’s competitiveness in global markets,” Joshi said.

India’s wind energy journey is gaining momentum through strong localisation, advanced

manufacturing capabilities and growing global competitiveness. He highlighted the country’s record addition of 6.1 GW of new wind power capacity during FY26, a 46 per cent year-on-year increase and the highest annual installation so

far, he said.

India is currently the world’s fourth-largest wind energy market with more than 56.1 GW of installed capacity, though less than 5 per cent of its estimated wind energy potential of 1,164 GW has been tapped. Industry stakeholders, including the Central Electricity Authority (CEA), The Energy and Resources Institute (TERI) and the National Institute of Wind Energy (NIWE), estimate that India will require over 100 GW of wind energy capacity by 2030 to support an affordable and sustainable energy transition.

A joint report by IWTMA

and PwC showed exports of wind turbines and related components crossed Rs 12,000 crore in FY26, nearly 50 per cent higher than the previous fiscal. The report estimates India’s share in global wind turbine exports could rise to 10 per cent by 2030 and 20 per cent by 2040.

Joshi also unveiled Suzlon Energy’s S175 (5 MW) wind turbine, commissioned at Vijayanagar in Karnataka. Featuring a 175-metre rotor, a 160-metre hybrid lattice tower and a 247.5-metre blade-tip height, the turbine is designed to access stronger wind layers and improve energy generation.

The minister said the new turbine would help India meet its wind energy ambitions while reflecting the country’s growing strength in advanced clean-energy innovation.

Speaking at the event, Chairman IWTMA Vice Chairman Suzlon Group, Girish Tanti said India has around 24 GW of annual wind manufacturing capacity and strong capabilities across nacelles, gearboxes, blades and towers, positioning it to scale annual wind installations to 15 GW by 2030 and capture 20 per cent of the global wind supply chain opportunity by 2040.

I think about ‘Delhi Belly 2’ almost every day: Abhinay Deo

The ‘Brown’ director explains why he is enamoured by the ‘grey’ world

ANINDITA ACHARYA

Nearly 15 years after directing the cult comedy ‘Delhi Belly’, filmmaker Abhinay Deo still thinks about revisiting the world of the film that redefined Hindi cinema’s dark humour.

“If the number of times I’ve thought about it had a penny attached to it, I would have been a millionaire by now,” he laughed.

The director admitted that he hopes a second chapter eventually materialises.

Deo, who followed up ‘Delhi Belly’ with acclaimed projects including the Indian adaptation of ‘24’ starring Anil Kapoor, has built a reputation for crafting stories that inhabit morally grey spaces. His latest offering, ‘Brown’ on ‘Zee5’, continues that tradition.

The gritty neo-noir crime thriller stars Karisma Kapoor as Rita Brown, a troubled Kolkata police officer investigating a murder while wrestling with her own demons. Based on Abheek Barua’s novel ‘City of Death’, the series uses Kolkata not merely as a backdrop but as a living, breathing character in the story.

“The series is based on a book set in Kolkata, so it was a natural choice. But beyond that, I have always been fascinated by the



city. As an architecture student, I was intrigued by its buildings, history and character. Interestingly, I had several opportunities to shoot advertising films in Kolkata over the years, but for one reason or another, they never happened. So, when ‘Brown’ came along, I decided I would finally spend time in the city and immerse myself in it,” he said.

The director remembered his first visit to Kolkata was in 1990 while travelling to Darjeeling. He remembers taking a rickshaw to

Eden Gardens.

Now, the premise of ‘Brown’ featuring a troubled police officer investigating a crime while battling personal demons is not uncommon in the web series world. But the ‘Blackmail’ director said the series is not just about the demons Rita Brown carries within herself. It is also about the demons society creates.

“‘Brown’ examines those hidden layers of human behaviour and asks uncomfortable questions about the people we



“With Karisma, what impressed me was her willingness to completely surrender to the character”

taste in cinema ‘extremely varied’. “What excites me is originality... Stories that surprise me and show me a side of life I hadn’t considered before,” he smiled.

‘Brown’ has an ensemble casting of Karisma, Helen, Soni Razdan and Jisshu Sengupta. The director is highly impressed with Karisma, who plays the protagonist.

“With Karisma, what impressed me was her willingness to completely surrender to the character. She wasn’t concerned about looking glamorous. Given her filmography, that level of commitment was wonderful to witness,” he said.

As for Helen, it was a fanboy moment for Deo.

“When I approached her, the first thing she asked was whether she would have to climb stairs because of her knees. I assured her that I would take care of that,” he said.

We again return to the ‘Delhi Belly’ conversation and how he has thought about a sequel countless times in these 15 years.

“The challenge is that ‘Delhi Belly’ involved several key collaborators, writer Akshat Verma, producer Aamir Khan, the cast and many others. Bringing everyone together again is not simple. But yes, I would love for it to happen. I think about it almost every day,” he said.

Veer Pahariya, Varun Sharma TO FEATURE IN ‘NAAM’

The plot details of the film are kept under wraps

New Delhi: Veer Pahariya and Varun Sharma are set to star in an action thriller titled ‘Naam’.

Presented by Mahesh Bhatt, the film is directed by Sidhaanth Sachdev, who has penned the script alongside Suhrita Das and Shweta Bothra. The film is produced by Riddhi Chawda and Utsav Upadhyay of ‘Utsav Entertainment and Productions’, according to a press release.

The plot details of the film are kept under wraps. Pahariya, the protagonist, will essay the role of an angry young man with grey shades and Sharma will step into the shoes of a fierce antagonist, the makers said.

“They are far more cinematically literate than we were. They have the thirst and urgency to create a place for themselves under the sun. If their collective drive can be used and funnelled down, then they will have a unique film in their hands,” Bhatt said about Pahariya and Sharma in a statement.

The film is backed by Meghna Hirawat Upadhyay and Kaveeta Agarwal of Alphaneon Studioz.



Pahariya, the protagonist, will essay the role of an angry young man with grey shades and Sharma will step into the shoes of a fierce antagonist



Tyra sues Netflix over ‘America’s Next Top Model’ documentary

Tyra Banks filed a defamation lawsuit against Netflix and the directors of its docuseries ‘Reality Check: Inside America’s Next Top Model’, alleging that the producers stripped down hours of interview footage to construct a false narrative.

In the lawsuit filed on Saturday in Los Angeles federal court, the model, who created and hosted ‘America’s Next Top Model’, said she was

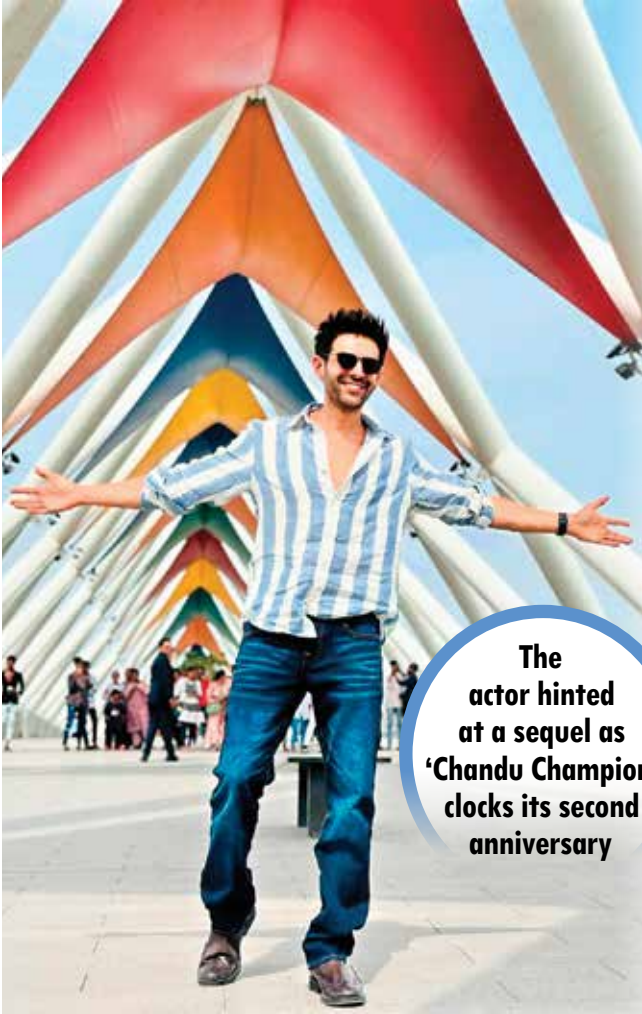
interviewed for three and a half hours, during which she took responsibility for some of the show’s controversial decisions. Those interviews were edited down to 16 minutes and manipulated to support a false and defamatory narrative unrelated to what she actually expressed, the lawsuit said.

“The accountability Tyra Banks took ended up on the cutting room floor. It was there, but viewers were never given

the opportunity to see it,” her lawyers wrote.

Banks is seeking damages in her lawsuit against ‘Netflix’, the directors Daniel Sivan and Mor Loushy and ‘EverWonder Studio’. She’s also seeking an injunction barring the use of her image in connection with the docuseries’ soundtrack, released as an album. Emails seeking comments were sent on Sunday to the defendants’ representatives.

AGENCIES



Champions will be back: Kartik Aaryan

Kartik Aaryan turned emotional as ‘Chandu Champion’ completed two years since its release. The actor took to social media to celebrate the occasion and shared a heartfelt note about the film he considers the most important project of his career. Kartik described the project as a life-changing experience. He opened up about the lessons he learned while portraying one of India’s most celebrated sporting heroes.

Sharing a photograph from the film, Kartik spoke about the emotional and physical challenges he faced while preparing for the role. He wrote, “Two years ago, I stepped into the shoes of a man the world had forgotten and he ended up reminding me of everything I believed in. I’m not sure I’ve fully put it into

words yet, but I’ll try. This film isn’t just about a man who refused to give up; it’s about the scars that become medals, setbacks that become comebacks. The 18 kilos I lost were nothing compared to everything I gained. #ChanduChampion is the most special film of my life. (sic)”

Kartik further revealed that playing Murlikant Petkar required him to push himself beyond his limits. He explained that the journey demanded discipline, perseverance and complete commitment.

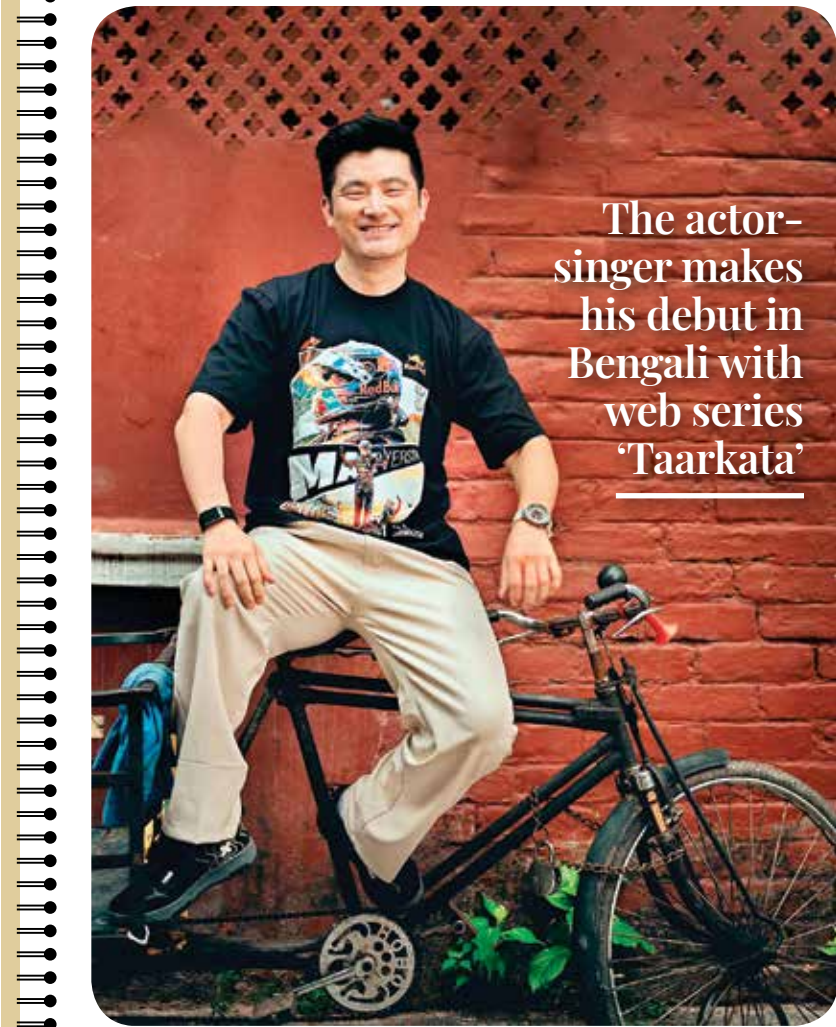
Reflecting on the experience, he wrote, “To play Murlikant Petkar, I had to become someone I’d never been before. Every early morning, every drop of sweat, every moment of self-doubt on set—it wasn’t acting. It was living. Chandu’s story taught me that the world will laugh at your dream before it applauds it, that the finish line belongs to those stub-

born enough to keep running. I carried that with me every single day of this shoot and honestly, I still do.”

Kartik also used the occasion to thank director Kabir Khan, producer Sajid Nadiadwala and the entire crew that worked on the film. Expressing his appreciation, he wrote, “Kabir Sir, thank you for trusting me with a story this sacred. Sajid Sir, for making it possible and always being that powerhouse!! And to every single person behind the camera, the ones who ran with me at 5 am; the ones who pushed me when I wanted to stop.”

Ending his post on an intriguing note, he wrote, “PS. Can’t wait to share with you all what we have next for you. Bas thoda sa intezaar... Champions will be back! Many fans began speculating about a sequel, a new project or another collaboration between the actor and the filmmaker.”

AGENCIES



The actor-singer makes his debut in Bengali with web series ‘Taarkata’

WE LOVE TO HATE WHAT WE DON’T UNDERSTAND: MEIYANG CHANG

URJA SAHA

From being a singer, actor and TV host to a dentist, Meiyang Chang comfortably wears many hats. He has been part of plum Bollywood films like ‘Badmaash Company’, ‘Detective Byomkesh Bakshi!’, ‘Bharat’ and ‘Sultan’, but that doesn’t stop the actor from trying something new.

“I’ve always wanted to do something in Bengali,” he said when we asked him about ‘Taarkata’, his first Bengali web series on ‘Zee5’, where Chang steps into the role of Dodo, the newly crowned Don.

The project not only marks a new chapter professionally but also reconnects him with the city that has played a pivotal role in his personal journey. Chang recalled his long-standing connection with Kolkata through family, friends and formative life experiences. While completing his dental studies and preparing for higher edu-



As an Indian of Chinese heritage, he has often stood out visually in the entertainment industry. While he said overt prejudice has decreased over the years, stereotypes have not disappeared entirely

cation, he travelled to Kolkata to audition for Indian Idol. And then, he got selected for ‘Indian Idol 3’ in 2007.

In ‘Taarkata’, Chang plays Dodo, a calculating and ruthless gangster who has climbed his way to the top of the criminal underworld. Unlike the loud, flamboyant villains often seen on screen, Dodo’s menace lies in his composure.

“Everything in his life is calculated and disciplined. That is what makes him dangerous,” Chang explained. Alongside Chang, the cast includes Vikram Chatterjee, Priyanka Sarkar and others. Chang found himself welcomed by the cast and crew, particularly lead actor and producer Vikram.

Despite appearances in films such as ‘Badmaash Com-

pany’, ‘Detective Byomkesh Bakshi!’, ‘Sultan’ and ‘Happy Patel: Khatarnak Jasoo’, it still feels like we don’t see Chang enough on the big screen. “I have no idea, actually,” he said. Part of the answer, he believes, lies in the industry’s changing landscape. “Theatrical cinema has changed so much because films arrive on OTT platforms very quickly now,” he explained.

At the same time, web series have offered him opportunities to explore layered characters and longer-form storytelling. “Shows like ‘Asur’, ‘Modern Love’ and now ‘Taarkata’ have allowed me to do some very interesting work. But there is still something special about watching a film in theatres,” he said.

As an Indian of Chinese heritage, Chang has often stood out visually in the entertainment industry. While he said overt prejudice has decreased over the years, stereotypes have not disappeared entirely. According to him, it keeps happening from time to time. He recalled moments during the COVID-19 pandemic and periods of geopolitical tension between India and China when anti-Chinese sentiments resurfaced. “We love to hate what we don’t understand,” he stated.

Chang believes increased exposure to different cultures through travel, media and the internet should have reduced such ignorance, yet discrimination persists.

“Whatever our colour is, whatever our ethnic features are, we have to understand that we’re all on the same boat,” he said.